

Understanding Composition and Rhetoric: An Introduction

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JULIE WARKENTIN, ED.



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Contents

<u>Acknowledgements</u>	vii
<u>Introduction</u>	viii
1. <u>The Fundamentals of Academic Writing</u>	1
2. <u>Modes of Reasoning and Persuasion</u>	20
3. <u>Using Evidence Effectively</u>	41
4. <u>Media Literacy and Communicating in Public Contexts</u>	70
5. <u>Preparing for Assignments: The Research Process</u>	80
6. <u>Parts of the Essay and Argumentative Models</u>	91
7. <u>Additional Resources</u>	109

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Introduction

Dear Students,

It is with great pleasure that the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences at Sheridan brings you this open access textbook for your course. In the spirit of educational equality and reducing barriers for our students, the goal in producing this text was to help support our students better in the pursuit of academic excellence. We sincerely hope that you find this book to be useful and that it serves you well during your English class this semester.

And please remember, in the words of Octavia E. Butler: “You don’t start out writing good stuff. You start out writing crap and thinking it’s good stuff, and then gradually you get better at it. That’s why I say one of the most valuable traits is persistence.”

Julie Warkentin and the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences

I. The Fundamentals of Academic Writing

Chapter 1 Content Summary:

- Understanding your Professors
- Why and how do Professors give Assignments?
- Purposes of Academic Writing
- Understanding Audience
- Understanding Tone

Welcome to your *Composition and Rhetoric* course! You may be wondering why you're taking yet another English class when you may have been required to take English classes throughout your educational career so far. You will be happy to know that this course is not about analyzing Shakespeare or talking about symbolism and metaphors; rather, the goal of this course is to help you to understand better what academic and professional writing is all about.

For many students, the focus of past English classes has been on *literary analysis* – reading and responding to (non)fiction works and analyzing them, typically in the form of an essay. Until now, you may never have had anyone formally teach you about the components that go into a good argument. Many students often find that they have just “picked it up” along the way. That’s where this course comes in.

Your chosen career path has a set of tools that are essential to anyone looking to become successful, and this course is about adding to that tool kit. *Composition and Rhetoric* focuses on empowering you, the student, to be able to research, write, and argue more efficiently and effectively. It’s about equipping you with the tools necessary to be successful in your other courses. But most importantly, it focuses on teaching you to *think critically* in personal, professional, and academic contexts.

Writing, particularly in academic settings, is about more than just putting words down on a page. It’s about the ability to argue, reason, and support your ideas with evidence. It’s about engaging with the ideas of others in a professional manner, even (or perhaps especially) when we find them to be uncomfortable for us. It’s about learning to communicate with others – your peers, professors, and employers – in a way that is articulate and respectful.

Words are too often thrown about carelessly, particularly in the digital age with social media platforms. People are able to post thoughts and feelings almost immediately as they experience them. Social media removes the time and space barriers that used to provide the room for reflection and consideration before expressing our thoughts on paper. If you stop to consider the *power* that words can have, we can begin to appreciate the importance of studying composition and rhetoric. Words can inspire change, start wars, lift people up, and destroy self-esteem. The ways in which we wield words can have a direct impact on our environment and those around us.

So how does all of this translate into your composition class? Understanding how to read for an intended audience, the purpose, the rhetorical strategies, and the compositional style of a piece of writing – be it in an academic or professional settings – helps us to navigate relationships and express ourselves more clearly. Moreover, these skills also help us to understand expectations that are being placed upon us as writers, which in the immediate context, helps students to get better grades.

The Origins of Higher Education: Understanding your Professors

College may look and feel similar to high school, and, for the most part, you already know how to perform your student role within this setting. However, there are some fundamental differences. The most obvious ones are that high school is mandatory (to a certain point), freely available, and a legal right. College is optional, costly, and performance-based. Most institutions will dismiss you if your grades don't meet a certain minimum. But college is different in more subtle ways as well, and those differences reflect the evolution of post-secondary education.

In their original ancient and medieval forms, universities were centers for scholarship, existing at the pleasure of the crown, church, or state. While centers of study go at least back to ancient Mesopotamia 2500 years BCE, the Islamic and European universities of the first and second millennium CE are usually considered the first of the modern model. Highly privileged people went to these universities as students, but they didn't really attend classes, write papers, and take exams like college students today. Instead they acted as independent, though novice, scholars: they read everything they could find in their areas of interest, attended lectures that expert scholars gave, and, if they were lucky, got some feedback from those scholars on their own work or assisted scholars in theirs.

Obviously, colleges and universities today are much more student-centered. However, the notion of a university or college as a center for scholarship and exchange still shapes how these institutions operate today. Here are some insights that can be helpful to have about your new professors:

1. **Professors are scholars, researchers, and artists, but they may not be trained as teachers:**

Your faculty members are among some of the best and brightest in their fields of study. However, many of your professors have had little to no formal training in **pedagogy** (the theory and practice of teaching). They're extensively trained in their scholarly or creative fields and well-versed in relevant theories, methods, and significant findings. Some taught classes during graduate school, but many professors come to their jobs as subject-matter experts but relative novices about teaching. Many professors apply themselves to the craft of teaching with the same creative and intellectual fervor that drew them into their fields. They attend conferences and presentations about effective teaching and learning, keep journals and portfolios to reflect on their teaching work, and read books and articles about cognitive neuroscience, trends in higher education, and the social worlds of their students. There are some professors who still see themselves in the classical model—as someone who delivers content through lectures and assesses performance through a final exam or term paper, but that approach is becoming more rare.

2. **Professors have competing obligations:**

While you may view your professors primarily as teachers, some faculty members might teach only one or two classes a semester, where others may teach many more. Your instructors are also collecting data, writing books and articles, making films, writing poetry, consulting with businesses and organizations, or inventing things. Some of your faculty also hold other roles in your institution. Some are department or program chairs/coordinators who deal with administrative matters in addition to teaching. Many will sit on other committees or have other institutional responsibilities, such as research obligations.

3. **Professors believe that education is a privilege and that students should drive their own learning:**

The assumption behind high-school instruction is that the teacher is the engine of learning. Consequently, a lot of time is spent in direct face-to-face instruction. Homework is for further practice to reinforce material from that day. Teachers will often tell students what each night's homework assignment is, follow up on missing work, and closely track students' progress. In contrast, the assumption behind college instruction is that professors are *facilitators* of your learning. Their job is to guide you and help you, but the initiative must come from the student. Your professors were the students who loved to learn – formally or informally – and come to the classroom with the understanding that they are there to help you on your educational journey. Consequently, college instructors think of class meetings as an opportunity to prepare you for the heavy-lifting that you'll be doing on your own. Sometimes that involves direct instruction (how to solve a particular kind of problem or analyze a particular kind

of text). More often, though, professors want to provide you with material not contained in the reading or facilitate active learning experiences based on what you read. Professors lay out a path for learning—much like how personal trainers develop exercise routines—but it is up to students (and athletes) to do the difficult work themselves.

Your professors are passionate about their fields, and they want to share their excitement with you as effectively as they can. However, they also know that *you* came to *them* on a voluntary basis, and they fully expect you to take responsibility for your own learning. Most professors love to be asked questions and interact with students. If you ever need help, do not hesitate to ask for advice on how you can improve.

College Writing is Different

The origins of post-secondary education help to explain why even skilled wordsmiths benefit from studying the assumptions and expectations behind college-level writing. College is a fundamentally different educational model; as a result the purposes and expectations for writing are different. You have learned many of the essential skills and practices of formal written communication throughout your schooling; now it's time to take your writing a step further.

It is not uncommon for students to find themselves frustrated at some point by a professor's inability to simply "tell us what you want!" While professors want to set you up to succeed, they may find their expectations hard to articulate, in part because they struggle to remember what it's like to be a beginner in the field. Often, however, the more important reason that professors won't just tell you what to do is that there simply isn't a particular "answer" they want you to give in a paper or essay. They want to see your own ambitious and careful analysis. Some students assume that they should be able to envision a paper and its thesis within minutes of receiving the assignment; if not, they complain that the assignment is unclear. Other students assume that every professor has a completely different set of expectations and, consequently, conclude that writing papers is just an unavoidable guessing game about entirely subjective and idiosyncratic standards. Neither of those assumptions are true. Good, well-constructed writing assignments are supposed to be challenging to write, and professors are, above all, looking for your own self-motivated intellectual work.

Despite some variations by discipline, college instructors are bringing similar standards to evaluating student work. The following illustrates especially well the scholarly mindset and independent work habits they expect students to bring to their work and the expectations of an academic audience:

- thorough understanding of audience, context, and purpose
- reflection on the subject matter,
- detailed attention to research conventions,
- skillful use of high-quality, credible, relevant sources

Professors want to see that you've thought through a problem and taken the time and effort to explain your thinking in precise language.

Don't get discouraged! On my first college paper I got a very low grade. It felt like a slap in the face because I was a straight-A student in high school. It's just a fact of life. Talk to your professor about what you could have done differently. This will help you be better prepared for future papers.

~Kaethe Leonard

The first principle of good communication is knowing your audience. This is where writing papers for classes gets kind of weird. Often when you write for an audience of one, you write a letter or email. But college papers aren't written like letters; they're written like articles for a hypothetical group of readers that you don't actually know much about. There's a fundamental mismatch between the real-life audience and the form your writing takes because, in post-secondary studies, you often *write specifically for your professors, but with a general academic audience in mind*.

Another basic tenet of good communication is clarifying the purpose of the communication and letting that purpose shape your decisions. Your professor wants to see you work through complex ideas and deepen your knowledge through the process of producing the paper. Each assignment—be it an argumentative paper, reaction paper, reflective paper, lab report, discussion question, blog post, essay exam, project proposal, or what have you—is ultimately about demonstrating your learning. To succeed with writing assignments (and to benefit from them) you first have to understand their learning-related purposes. As you write for the hypothetical academic audience, you're demonstrating to your professor how far you've gotten in analyzing your topic.

Professors don't assign writing lightly. Grading student work is generally the hardest, most intensive work instructors do. With every assignment they give you, professors assign themselves many, many hours of demanding and intense work that has to be completed while they are also preparing for teaching classes, advancing their scholarly and creative work, advising students, and serving on committees.

You would do well to approach every assignment by putting yourself in the shoes of your instructor and asking yourself, "Why did they give me this assignment? How does it fit into the learning goals of the course? Why is this question/topic/problem so important to my professor that they are willing to spend evenings and weekends reading and commenting on several dozen papers on it?"

Most instructors do a lot to make their pedagogical goals and expectations transparent to students: they explain the course learning goals associated with assignments, provide grading rubrics in advance, and describe several strategies for succeeding. Other professors ... not so much. Some students perceive more open-ended assignments as evidence of a lazy, uncaring, or even incompetent instructor. In fact, some professors make a point to give very few parameters about an assignment—perhaps just a topic and a length requirement—and they likely have some good reasons for doing so. Here are some possible reasons:

1. **They figured it out themselves when they were students.** Unsurprisingly, your instructors were generally successful students who relished the culture and traditions of higher education so much that they strove to build an academic career. The current emphasis on student-centered teaching is relatively recent; your instructors often had professors who adhered to the classic model of college instruction: they attended lectures and wrote, perhaps, one or two essays in an entire semester. Students were on their own to learn the vocabulary and conventions of each field, to identify the key concepts and ideas within readings and lectures, and to sleuth out instructors' expectations for written work. Classes like *Composition and Rhetoric* were often not offered for your faculty. Learning goals, rubrics, quizzes, and preparatory assignments were generally rare, and so they may be teaching you how they themselves were taught.
2. **They think figuring it out yourself is good for you.** Because your professors by and large succeeded in a much less supportive environment, they appreciate how learning to thrive in those conditions gave them life-long problem-solving skills. Many think that you *should* be able to figure it out yourself and that it would be good practice for you to do so. Even those who do include a lot of guidance with writing assignments sometimes worry that they're depriving you of an important personal and intellectual challenge: figuring out unspoken expectations is a valuable skill in itself that serves students well in preparation for the workplace.
3. **They have been at this for a long time.** Many of your instructors have become so immersed in their fields that they may struggle to remember what it was like to encounter a wholly new discipline for the first time. The assumptions, practices, and culture of their disciplines are sometimes all that they know; so much so that it is hard to describe to new learners. They may assume that a verb like "analyze" is self-evident, forgetting that it can mean very different things in different fields. As a student, you voluntarily came to study with the scholars, artists, and writers at your institution. To meet them in the middle, you will need to put in the time and dedication to

demonstrate your willingness to learn.

It is understandably frustrating when you feel you don't know how to direct your efforts to succeed with an assignment. However, except for rare situations, you would do well to assume the best of your instructor and to appreciate the diversity of learning opportunities you have access to in college. One first-year student likened it to solving a puzzle: "I think that every course, every assignment, is a different little puzzle I have to solve. What do I need to do here? When do I need to do it, and how long will it take? What does this teacher expect of me?" The transparency that you get from some professors—along with courses and books like this one—will be a big help to you adapt in situations where you have to be scrappier and more pro-active, piecing together the clues you get from your professors, the readings, and other course documents.

What's Critical about *Critical Thinking*?

Why do your faculty bother with written assessments? One reason is that your professors are there to help impart knowledge to you, and assessments help them to determine how well you are understanding, reflecting upon, and applying the skills and concepts being taught in their classes. Second, and more importantly, your instructors are trying to teach you to think critically for an ever-increasingly complex world. **Critical thinking** is one of those terms that has been used so often and in so many different ways that it often seems meaningless; however, it is arguably the one skill that will set you up for the greatest successes in your career.

Critical thinking actually does mean something specific. The Association of American Colleges and Universities usefully defines it as "a habit of mind characterized by the comprehensive exploration of issues, ideas, artifacts, and events before accepting or formulating an opinion or conclusion."¹

[The critical thinking rubric](#), produced by the AAC&U, describes the relevant activities of critical thinking in more detail. To think critically, one must ...

- (a) "clearly state and comprehensively describe the issue or problem",
- (b) "independently interpret and evaluate sources",
- (c) "thoroughly analyze assumptions behind and context of your own or others' ideas",
- (d) "argue a complex position and one that takes counter-arguments into account," and
- (e) "arrive at logical and well informed conclusions".²

While you are probably used to providing some evidence for your claims, you can see that post-secondary expectations go quite a bit further. When professors assign an analytical paper, they don't just want you to formulate a plausible-sounding argument. They want you to dig into the evidence, think hard about unspoken assumptions and the influence of context, and then explain what you really think and why. For this reason, it is vital that you understand the **Assignment Prompt** before you even begin the writing process.

1. Terrel Rhodes, ed., *Assessing Outcomes and Improving Achievement: Tips and Tools for Using Rubrics* (Washington, DC: Association of American Colleges and Universities, 2010).
2. Ibid

The Assignment Prompt

Often, the handout or other written text explaining the assignment—what professors call the [assignment prompt](#) or outline – will explain the purpose of the assignment, the required parameters (length, number and type of sources, referencing style, etc.), and the criteria for evaluation. Sometimes, though—especially when you are new to a field—you will encounter the baffling situation in which you comprehend every single sentence in the prompt but still have absolutely no idea how to approach the assignment. No one is doing anything wrong in a situation like that. It just means that further dissection of the assignment is in order. Here are some tips:

1. **Focus on the [verbs](#).** Look for verbs like “compare,” “explain,” “justify,” “reflect” or the all-purpose “analyze.” You’re not just producing a paper as an artifact; you’re conveying, in written communication, some intellectual work you have done. So the question is, what kind of thinking are you supposed to do to deepen your learning?
2. **Put the assignment in context.** Many professors think in terms of [assignment sequences](#). For example, a social science professor may ask you to write about a controversial issue three times: first, arguing for one side of the debate; second, arguing for another; and finally, from a more comprehensive and nuanced perspective, incorporating text produced in the first two assignments. A sequence like that is designed to help you think through a complex issue. Another common one is a scaffolded research sequence (such as you will find in this course): you first propose a topic, then prepare an annotated bibliography, then a first draft, then a research presentation, then a final draft, and, perhaps, a reflection at the end. The preparatory assignments help ensure that you’re on the right track, beginning the research process long before the final due date, and taking the time to consider recasting your thesis, finding additional sources, or reorganizing your discussion. If the assignment isn’t part of a sequence, think about where it falls in the semester, and how it relates to readings and other assignments. Are there headings on the [syllabus](#) (also called a course/topical outline) that indicate larger units of material or course themes/concept? For example, if you see that a paper comes at the end of a three-week unit on the role of the Internet in organizational behavior, then your professor likely wants you to synthesize that material in your own way. You should also check your notes and online course resources for any other guidelines about the workflow. Maybe you got a rubric a couple weeks ago and forgot about it. Maybe your instructor posted a link about “how to make an annotated bibliography” but then forgot to mention it in class.
3. **Try a free-write or brainstorming.** A free-write is when you just write, without stopping, for a set period of time. That doesn’t sound very “free;” it actually sounds kind of coerced. The “free” part is *what* you write—it can be whatever comes to mind. Professional writers use free-writing to get started on a challenging (or distasteful) writing task or to overcome writers block or a powerful urge to procrastinate. The idea is that if you just make yourself write, you can’t help but produce some kind of useful nugget. Thus, even if the first eight sentences of your free write are all variations on “I don’t understand this” or “I’d really rather be doing something else,” eventually you’ll write something like “I guess the main point of this is ...” and you’re off and running. Mind Maps and other brainstorming techniques are just as useful. If your instructor doesn’t make time for that in class, a quick free-write on your own will quickly reveal whether you need clarification about the assignment and, often, what questions to ask.
4. **Ask for clarification the right way.** Even the most skillfully crafted assignments may need some verbal clarification, especially because students’ familiarity with the field can vary enormously. Asking for clarification is a good thing. Be aware, though, that instructors get frustrated when they perceive that students want to skip doing their own thinking and instead receive an exact recipe for an A paper. Go ahead and ask for clarification, but try to convey that you want to learn and you’re ready to work.

In general, avoid starting a question with “Do we have to ...” because your instructor might be thinking, “You don’t *have* to do anything. You’re an adult. You chose college. You’re free to exercise your right to fail.” Similarly, avoid

asking the professor about what he or she “wants.” You’re not performing some service for the professor when you write a paper. What they “want” is for you to really think about the material.

Potentially annoying questions	Preferable alternatives
I don't get it. Can you explain this more? or What do you want us to do?	I see that we are comparing and contrasting these two cases. What should be our focus? Their causes? Their impacts? Their implications? All of those things? or I'm unfamiliar with how art historians analyze a painting. Could you say more about what questions I should have in mind to do this kind of analysis?
How many sources do we have to cite?	Is there a typical range for the number of sources a well written paper would cite for this assignment? or Could you say more about what the sources are for? Is it more that we're analyzing these texts in this paper, or are we using these texts to analyze some other case?
What do I have to do to get an A on this paper?	Could I meet with you to get feedback on my (pre-prepared) plans/outline/thesis? or I'm not sure how to approach this assignment. Are there any good examples or resources you could point me to?

As was mentioned earlier, most professors – whether they are aware of it or not – choose their **verbs** very carefully when designing an assignment. These verbs correlate with different levels of learning and objectives that the professor wants to see, and they have often learned how to use them through trial and error during their own time in school. Knowing what directions are associated with different verbs can save you a lot of time and aggravation as a student.

Consider the following chart, which provides examples of some assignments, describes them, gives an example, and outlines some common verbs your professor might use in an assignment outline of this type:

Assignment Type	Description	Example	Common Verbs Associated
Personal response paper	Expresses and explains your response to a reading assignment, a provocative quote, or a specific issue; may be very brief (sometimes a page or less) or more in depth	For a labour management course, students watch and write about videos of ineffective management/ staff interactions.	Reflect, consider, discuss, think, assess, evaluate
Summary	Restates the main points of a longer passage objectively and in your own words	For a psychology course, students write a one-page summary of an article about a man suffering from short-term memory loss.	summarize, outline, highlight
Persuasive/ position paper	States and defends your position on an issue (often a controversial issue)	For a criminal justice course, students state their positions on capital punishment using research to support their argument.	argue, defend, persuade, convince
Problem-solution paper	Presents a problem, explains its causes, and proposes and explains a solution	For an emergency management course, a student presents a plan for implementing a crisis communications strategy.	discuss, plan, create, generate, explain, analyze
Critique/ literary analysis	States a thesis about a particular literary work and develops the thesis with evidence from the work and, sometimes, from additional sources	For a literature course, a student analyzes a short story by Ian Rankin and how it relates to the field of criminology OR compares multiple works by analyzing commonalities and differences.	argue, evaluate, critique, compare, analyze, assess
Research/ literature review	Sums up available research findings on a particular topic	For a course in criminology, a student reviews the past 20 years of research on whether violence in television and movies is correlated with violent behaviour.	summarize, review, analyze, discuss, evaluate, consider
Case study or case analysis	Investigates a particular person, group, or event in depth for the purpose of drawing a larger conclusion from the analysis	For a health science course, a student writes a case study demonstrating the successful treatment of a patient experiencing congestive heart failure.	apply, discuss, analyze, evaluate, create, conclude
Laboratory report	Presents a laboratory experiment, including the hypothesis, methods of data collection, results, and conclusions	For a psychology course, a group of students presents the results of an experiment in which they explored whether sleep deprivation produced memory deficits in lab rats.	discuss, hypothesize, present, conclude
Research journal	Records a student's ideas and findings during the course of a long-term research project	For a capstone project, a student maintains a journal throughout a semester-long research project within the local fire department.	reflect, analyze, critique, connect, assess, evaluate
Research paper	Presents a thesis and supports it with original research and/or other researchers' findings on the topic; can take several different formats depending on the subject area	For a criminology course, a student chooses a topic/thesis on de-escalation techniques and conducts background research on existing evidence then creates his or her own research tool to measure the effectiveness of such techniques.	discuss, reflect, analyze, consider, evaluate

Student Tip

If you don't know what a particular verb means, be sure to [look it up](#) so that you understand what your instructor is looking for and asking you to do in the assignment!

Rubrics as Road Maps

If a professor provides a grading **rubric** (a mark sheet breakdown) with an assignment prompt, you're already ahead of the game. If the professor took the trouble to prepare and distribute it, you can be sure that they will use it to grade your paper. They may not go over it in class, but it's the clearest possible statement of what the professor is looking for in the paper. If it's wordy, it may seem like those online "terms and conditions" that we routinely accept without reading. But you really should read it over carefully before you begin and again as your work progresses. A lot of rubrics do have some useful specifics. Even less specific criteria (such as "incorporates course concepts" and "considers counter-arguments") will tell you how you should be spending your writing time.

Even the best rubrics aren't completely transparent. They simply can't be. For example, what is the real difference between "demonstrating a thorough understanding of context, audience, and purpose" and "demonstrating adequate consideration" of the same? It depends on the specific context. So how can you know whether you've done that? A big part of what you're learning, through feedback from your professors, is to judge the quality of your writing for yourself. Your future employers are counting on that ability. At this point, it is better to think of rubrics as roadmaps, displaying your destination, rather than a GPS system directing every move you make.

Behind any rubric is the essential goal of higher education: helping you take charge of your own learning, which means writing like an independently motivated scholar. Are you tasked with proposing a research paper topic? Don't just tell the professor what you want to do, convince him or her of the salience of your topic, as if you were a scholar seeking grant money. Is it a reflection paper? Then outline both the insights you've gained and the intriguing questions that remain, as a scholar would. Are you writing a thesis-driven analytical paper? Then apply the concepts you've learned to a new problem or situation. Write as if your scholarly peers around the country are eagerly awaiting your unique insights. Descriptors like "thoroughness" or "mastery" or "detailed attention" convey the vision of student writers making the time and rigorous mental effort to offer something new to the ongoing, multi-stranded academic conversation. What your professor wants, in short, is critical thinking.

Writing in Specific Academic Contexts

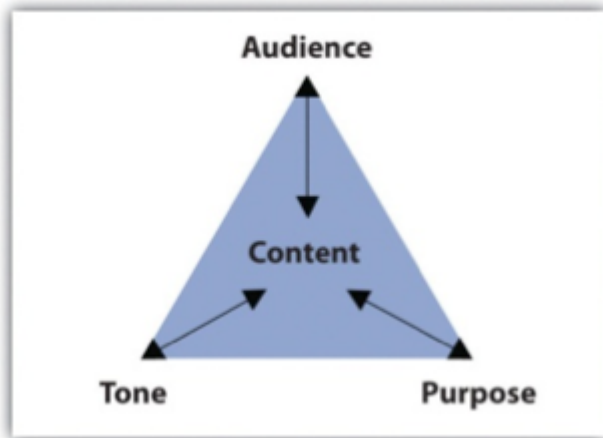
Each academic discipline will have its own ways of establishing knowledge (**epistemology**) and methods for conducting research/asking questions (**methodology**). In the sciences or business, reports are a common mode for writing. In the humanities and social sciences, one of the most common forms of writing is the essay, but it's worth noting that different subjects (history, philosophy, literature) will use different styles of essay. Because each essay has a different purpose, we need to look further at how to construct paragraphs according to the purpose, audience, and tone of writing.

It is important keep the big picture thesis in mind when writing, and to question whether the information supports that thesis. As well, while thinking of how each supporting idea links back to that thesis, it is necessary to consider the purpose of the paragraphs. Should a paragraph be summary, analysis, synthesis, or evaluation to best support the thesis and essay mode? How will that purpose affect paragraph construction?

Three elements shape the content of each paragraph (The **Purpose, Audience, Tone, and Content Triangle** below illustrates this concept):

1. **Purpose.** The reason the writer composes the paragraph.
2. **Tone.** The attitude the writer conveys about the paragraph's subject.
3. **Audience.** The individual or group whom the writer intends to address.

Purpose, Audience, Tone, and Content Triangle



The assignment's purpose, audience, and tone dictate what the paragraph covers and how it will support one main point. This section covers how purpose, audience, and tone affect reading and writing paragraphs.

Identifying Common Academic Purposes: Understanding Your Assignments

In academic settings, the reasons for writing typically fulfill four main purposes: to summarize, to analyze, to synthesize, and to evaluate. Each of these terms means something different, and you will encounter these four purposes not only as you read for your classes but also as you read for work or pleasure. Because reading and writing work together, your writing skills will improve as you read.

Eventually, your instructors likely will ask you to complete assignments specifically designed to meet one of the four

aforementioned purposes. As you will see, the purpose for writing will guide you through each part of the paper, helping you make decisions about content and style.

Summaries

A **summary** involves capturing the most significant, salient points from another body of work. Summaries are about “just the facts” and involve condensing a large amount of information into a shorter or smaller version. Think about the last movie that you saw or book that you read. Can you, **in your own words**, explain what it was about? The most important part of a summary is that you are not copying what the original source said – you are giving the details using your own words and explanation.

Summary often involves the “5 Ws”: *who, what, where, when, why* (and sometimes *how*).

Analysis Paragraphs

An **analysis** separates complex materials into their different parts and studies how the parts relate to one another. The analysis of simple table salt, for example, would require a deconstruction of its parts—the elements sodium (Na) and chloride (Cl). Then, scientists would study how the two elements interact to create the compound NaCl, or sodium chloride, which is also called simple table salt.

Analysis is not limited to the sciences, of course. An analysis paragraph in academic writing fulfills the same purpose. Instead of deconstructing chemical compounds, academic analysis paragraphs typically deconstruct documents. An analysis takes apart a primary source (an essay, a book, an article, etc.) point by point. It communicates the main points of the document by examining individual points and identifying how they relate to one another. Take a look at a student’s analysis of the journal report:

At the beginning of their report, Brown et al. use specific data regarding the use of alcohol by high school students and college-aged students, which is supported by several studies. Later in the report, they consider how various socioeconomic factors influence problem drinking in adolescence. The latter part of the report is far less specific and does not provide statistics or examples.

The lack of specific information in the second part of the report raises several important questions. Why are teenagers in rural high schools more likely to drink than teenagers in urban areas? Where do they obtain alcohol? How do parental attitudes influence this trend? A follow-up study could compare several high schools in rural and urban areas to consider these issues and potentially find ways to reduce teenage alcohol consumption.

Notice how the analysis does not simply repeat information from the original report (as would a summary), but considers

how the points within the report relate to one another. By doing this, the student uncovers a discrepancy between the points that are backed up by statistics and those that require additional information. Analyzing a document involves a close examination of each of the individual parts and how they work together.

Synthesis Paragraphs

A **synthesis** combines two or more items to create an entirely new item. Consider the electronic musical instrument aptly named the synthesizer. It looks like a simple keyboard but displays a dashboard of switches, buttons, and levers. With the flip of a few switches, a musician may combine the distinct sounds of a piano, a flute, or a guitar—or any other combination of instruments—to create a new sound. The purpose of the synthesizer is to blend together the notes from individual instruments to form new, unique notes.

The purpose of an academic synthesis is to blend individual documents into a new document. An academic synthesis paragraph considers the main points from one or more pieces of writing and links the main points together to create a new point, one not replicated in either document.

Take a look at a student's synthesis of several sources about underage drinking:

In their 2009 report, Brown et al. consider the rates of alcohol consumption among high school and college-aged students and various sociodemographic factors that affect these rates. However, this report is limited to assessing the rates of underage drinking, rather than considering methods of decreasing these rates. Several other studies, as well as original research among college students, provide insight into how these rates may be reduced.

One study, by Spoth, Greenberg, and Turrisi (2009) considers the impact of various types of interventions as a method for reducing alcohol consumption among minors. They conclude that although family-focused interventions for adolescents aged ten to fifteen have shown promise, there is a serious lack of interventions available for college-aged students who do not attend college. These students are among the highest risk level for alcohol abuse, a fact supported by Brown et al.

I did my own research and interviewed eight college students, four men and four women. I asked them when they first tried alcohol and what factors encouraged them to drink. All four men had tried alcohol by the age of thirteen. Three of the women had also tried alcohol by thirteen and the fourth had tried alcohol by fifteen. All eight students said that peer pressure, boredom, and the thrill of trying something illegal were motivating factors. These results support the research of Brown et al. However, they also raise an interesting point. If boredom is a motivating factor for underage drinking, maybe additional after school programs or other community measures could be introduced to dissuade teenagers from underage drinking. Based on my sources, further research is needed to show true preventative measures for teenage alcohol consumption.

Notice how the synthesis paragraphs consider each source and use information from each to create a new thesis. A good synthesis does not repeat information; the writer uses a variety of sources to create a new idea.

Evaluation Paragraphs

An **evaluation** judges the value of something and determines its effectiveness. Evaluations in everyday experiences are often not only dictated by set standards but are also influenced by opinion and prior knowledge. For example, at work,

a supervisor may complete an employee evaluation by judging his subordinate's performance based on the company's goals. If the company focuses on improving communication, the supervisor will rate the employee's customer service according to a standard scale. However, the evaluation still depends on the supervisor's opinion and prior experience with the employee. The purpose of the evaluation is to determine how well the employee performs on the job.

An academic evaluation communicates your opinion, and its justifications, about a document or a topic of discussion. Evaluations are influenced by your reading of the document, your prior knowledge, and your prior experience with the topic or issue. Because an evaluation incorporates your point of view and the reasons for your point of view, it typically requires more critical thinking and a combination of summary, analysis, and synthesis skills. Thus evaluation paragraphs often follow summary, analysis, and synthesis paragraphs.

Notice how the example below incorporates the student's personal judgment within the evaluation. Evaluating a document requires prior knowledge that is often based on additional research:

Throughout their report, Brown et al. provide valuable statistics that highlight the frequency of alcohol use among high school and college students. They use several reputable sources to support their points. However, the report focuses solely on the frequency of alcohol use and how it varies according to certain sociodemographic factors. Other sources, such as Spoth, Greenberg, and Turrisi's study (2009) and the survey I conducted among college students, examine the reasons for alcohol use among young people and offer suggestions as to how to reduce the rates. Nonetheless, I think that Brown et al. offer a useful set of statistics from which to base further research into alcohol use among high school and college students.

Self-Practice Exercise

Read the following paragraphs about four films and then identify the purpose of each paragraph.

1. This film could easily have been cut down to less than two hours. By the final scene, I noticed that most of my fellow moviegoers were snoozing in their seats and were barely paying attention to what was

happening on screen. Although the director sticks diligently to the book, he tries too hard to cram in all the action, which is just too ambitious for such a detail-oriented story. If you want my advice, read the book and give the movie a miss.

2. During the opening scene, we learn that the character Laura is adopted and that she has spent the past three years desperately trying to track down her real parents. Having exhausted all the usual options—adoption agencies, online searches, family trees, and so on—she is on the verge of giving up when she meets a stranger on a bus. The chance encounter leads to a complicated chain of events that ultimately result in Laura getting her lifelong wish. But is it really what she wants? Throughout the rest of the film, Laura discovers that sometimes the past is best left where it belongs.

3. To create the feeling of being gripped in a vise, the director, May Lee, uses a variety of elements to gradually increase the tension. The creepy, haunting melody that subtly enhances the earlier scenes becomes ever more insistent, rising to a disturbing crescendo toward the end of the movie. The desperation of the actors, combined with the claustrophobic atmosphere and tight camera angles create a realistic firestorm, from which there is little hope of escape. Walking out of the theatre at the end feels like staggering out of a Roman dungeon.

4. The scene in which Campbell and his fellow prisoners assist the guards in shutting down the riot immediately strikes the viewer as unrealistic. Based on the recent reports on prison riots in both Detroit and California, it seems highly unlikely that a posse of hardened criminals would intentionally help their captors at the risk of inciting future revenge from other inmates. Instead, both news reports and psychological studies indicate that prisoners who do not actively participate in a riot will go back to their cells and avoid conflict altogether. Examples of this lack of attention to detail occur throughout the film, making it almost unbearable to watch.

Collaboration: Share with a classmate and compare your answers.

Writing at Work

Thinking about the purpose of writing a report in the workplace can help focus and structure the document. A summary should provide colleagues with a factual overview of your findings without going into too much detail. In contrast, an evaluation should include your personal opinion, along with supporting evidence, research, or examples to back it up. **Listen for words such as *summarize*,**

analyze, synthesize, or evaluate when your employer asks you to complete a report to help determine a purpose for writing.

Identifying the Audience

Imagine you must give a presentation to a group of executives in an office. Weeks before the big day, you spend time creating and rehearsing the presentation. You must make important, careful decisions not only about the content but also about your delivery. Will the presentation require technology to project figures and charts? Should the presentation define important words, or will the executives already know the terms? Should you wear your suit and dress shirt? The answers to these questions will help you develop an appropriate relationship with your audience, making them more receptive to your message.

Now imagine you must explain the same business concepts from your presentation to a group of high school students. Those important questions you previously answered may now require different answers. The figures and charts may be too sophisticated, and the terms will certainly require definitions. You may even reconsider your outfit and sport a more casual look. Because the audience has shifted, your presentation and delivery will shift as well to create a new relationship with the new audience.

In these two situations, the **audience**—the individuals who will watch and listen to the presentation—plays a role in the development of presentation – including those lessons that your own professors deliver! As you prepare the presentation, you visualize the audience to anticipate their expectations and reactions. What you imagine affects the information you choose to present and how you will present it. Then, during the presentation, you meet the audience in person and discover immediately how well you perform.

Although the audience for writing assignments—your readers—may not appear in person, they play an equally vital role. Even in everyday writing activities, you identify your readers' characteristics, interests, and expectations before making decisions about what you write. In fact, thinking about audience has become so common that you may not even detect the audience driven decisions.

For example, you update your status on a social networking site with the awareness of who will digitally follow the post. If you want to brag about a good grade, you may write the post to please family members. If you want to describe a funny moment, you may write with your friends' sense of humour in mind. Even at work, you send emails with an awareness of an unintended receiver who could intercept the message.

In other words, being aware of “invisible” readers is a skill you most likely already possess and one you rely on every day. Consider the following paragraphs. Which one would the author send to their parents? Which one would they send to their best friend?

Example A

Last Saturday, I volunteered at a local hospital. The visit was fun and rewarding. I even learned how to do cardiopulmonary resuscitation, or CPR. Unfortunately, I think caught a cold from one of the patients. This week, I will rest in bed and drink plenty of clear fluids. I hope I am well by next Saturday to volunteer again.

Example B

OMG! You won't believe this! My advisor forced me to do my community service hours at this hospital all weekend! We learned CPR but we did it on dummies, not even real peeps. And some kid sneezed on me and got me sick! I was so bored and sniffing all weekend; I hope I don't have to go back next week. I def do NOT want to miss the basketball tournament!

Most likely, you matched each paragraph to its intended audience with little hesitation. Because each paragraph reveals the author's relationship with her intended readers, you can identify the audience fairly quickly. When writing your own paragraphs, you must engage with your audience to build an appropriate relationship given your subject. Imagining your readers during each stage of the writing process will help you make decisions about your writing. Ultimately, the people you visualize will affect what and how you write.

Because focusing on audience will enhance your writing, your process, and your finished product, you must consider the specific traits of your audience members. Use your imagination to anticipate the readers' demographics, education, prior knowledge, and expectations.

- **Demographics:** These measure important data about a group of people, such as their age range, ethnicity, religious beliefs, or gender. Certain topics and assignments will require you to consider these factors as they relate to your audience. For other topics and assignments, these measurements may not influence your writing. Regardless, it is important to consider demographics when you begin to think about your purpose for writing.
- **Education:** Education considers the audience's level of schooling. If audience members have earned a doctorate degree, for example, you may need to elevate your style and use more formal language. Or, if audience members

are still in college, you could write in a more relaxed style. An audience member's major or emphasis may also dictate your writing.

- **Prior knowledge:** Prior knowledge is what the audience already knows about your topic. If your readers have studied certain topics, they may already know some terms and concepts related to the topic. You may decide whether to define terms and explain concepts based on your audience's prior knowledge. Although you cannot peer inside the brains of your readers to discover their knowledge, you can make reasonable assumptions. For instance, a nursing major would presumably know more about health-related topics than a business major would.
- **Expectations:** These indicate what readers will look for while reading your assignment. Readers may expect consistencies in the assignment's appearance, such as correct grammar and traditional formatting like double-spaced lines and a legible font. Readers may also have content-based expectations given the assignment's purpose and organization. In an essay titled "The Economics of Enlightenment: The Effects of Rising Tuition," for example, audience members may expect to read about the economic repercussions of post-secondary tuition costs.

Keep in mind that as your topic shifts in the writing process, your audience may also shift. Also, remember that decisions about style depend on audience, purpose, and content. Identifying your audience's demographics, education, prior knowledge, and expectations will affect how you write, but purpose and content play an equally important role. The next subsection covers how to select an appropriate tone to match the audience and purpose.

Selecting Appropriate Tone

Tone identifies a speaker's attitude toward a subject or another person. In speech, tone is conveyed by word choice, intonation, volume, and body language/facial expressions. You may pick up a person's tone of voice fairly easily in conversation. A friend who tells you about her weekend may speak excitedly about a fun skiing trip. An instructor who means business may speak in a low, slow voice to emphasize her serious mood. Or, a co-worker who needs to let off some steam after a long meeting may crack a sarcastic joke. Tone is important because the way you might speak to your friends ("oh shut up, it's fine...") would definitely not be appropriate when speaking to your employer or your professor.

Just as speakers transmit emotion through voice, writers can transmit through writing a range of attitudes, from excited and humorous to somber and critical. These emotions create connections among the audience, the author, and the subject, ultimately building a relationship between the audience and the text. To stimulate these connections, writers intimate their attitudes and feelings with useful devices, such as sentence structure, word choice, punctuation, emojis, and formal or informal language. Keep in mind that the writer's attitude should always appropriately match the audience and the purpose, which means that you need to choose appropriate language and sentence structure that will convey your ideas with your intent.

Read the following paragraph and consider the writer's tone. How would you describe the writer's attitude toward wildlife conservation?

Many species of plants and animals are disappearing right before our eyes. If we do not act fast, it might be too late to save them. Human activities, including pollution, deforestation, hunting, and overpopulation, are devastating the natural environment. Without our help, many species will not survive long enough for our children to see them in the wild. Take the tiger, for example. Today, tigers occupy just 7 percent of their historical range, and many local populations are already extinct. Hunted for their beautiful pelt and other body parts, the tiger population has plummeted from 100,000 in 1920 to just a few thousand (Smith, 2013). Contact your local wildlife conservation society today to find out how you can stop this terrible destruction.

Choosing Appropriate, Interesting Content

Content refers to all the written substance in a document – the ideas and information contained within it. After selecting an audience and a purpose, you must choose what information will make it to the page. Content may consist of **evidence**, such as examples, statistics, facts, anecdotes, testimonies, and observations, but no matter the type, the information must be appropriate and interesting for the audience and purpose. An essay written for grade 3 students that summarizes the legislative process, for example, would have to contain succinct and simple content.

Content is also shaped by tone. When the tone matches the content, the audience will be more engaged, and you will build a stronger relationship with your readers. Consider that audience of grade 3 students. You would choose simple content that the audience will easily understand, and you would express that content through an enthusiastic tone. The same considerations will apply to all audiences and purposes as we continue to develop academic and professional writing and communication skills.

Key Terms and Concepts

- Pedagogy
- Epistemology
- Methodology
- Assignment Verbs
- Rubric
- Purpose
- Audience
- Tone
- Content

2. Modes of Reasoning and Persuasion

Chapter 2 Content Summary:

- Language and Bias in Writing
- Modes of Reasoning
- Logic and Parts of an Argument
- Forms of Reasoning
- Fallacies

Language and Bias in Arguments

The Rhetorical Appeals

Described by Aristotle in *Rhetoric* as “modes of persuasion,” the **rhetorical appeals** are three categories which help us to classify our methods for appealing to an audience when presenting an argument. Called **ethos**, **pathos**, and **logos**, these categories help us to identify how or why an argument is (in)effective in achieving its purpose:

Ethos: *Appeals to trust and credibility.* This appeal is perhaps one of the most commonly used in day-to-day conversation. When we refer to experts and what they say to support our own assertions, we are appealing to an audience through ethos. Little kids do this a lot: “well, my parent says...” is how children bring ethos (the authority and credibility of a parent) into conversations to help support their arguments. At an adult level, people will often reference “something they heard on the news/social media/radio” as a means of invoking authority and credibility to support their point.

Pathos: *Appeals to emotions.* This appeal is the most unpredictable one, but it can certainly be extremely effective if used well. When appealing to an audience through pathos, an author is trying to create an emotional connection with audiences and/or between the audience and the argument being presented. When someone is convinced to “think with emotions” and relies on feelings rather than logic, pathos is being used effectively in an argument.

Logos: *Appeals to logic.* Logos is often the “go-to” appeal for academics because logic presupposes a shared, common understanding of something. Even if one doesn’t necessarily *agree* with the argument being presented due to personal ethics, morals, or points of view, one would be hard-pressed to disagree with the soundness or validity of the argument if it is logical. When a point is presented in a logical manner that you can accept (even if you don’t agree), logos is being used effectively.

Acknowledging Opposing Ideas and Limits to Your Argument

Because an argument implies differing points of view on the subject, you must be sure to acknowledge those opposing ideas and sides. Avoiding ideas that conflict with your own gives the reader the impression that you may be uncertain, fearful, or unaware of opposing ideas. Thus, it is essential that you not only address counterarguments, but that you do so respectfully.

Try to address opposing arguments earlier rather than later in your essay. Rhetorically speaking, ordering your positive arguments last allows you to better address ideas that conflict with your own, so you can spend the rest of the essay countering those arguments. This way, you leave your reader thinking about your argument rather than someone else's. You have the last word. Moreover, acknowledging different points of view also fosters more credibility between you and the audience. They know from the outset that you are aware of opposing ideas and that you are not afraid to give them space.

It is also helpful to establish the limits of your argument and what you are trying to accomplish. In effect, you are conceding early on that your argument is not the ultimate authority on a given topic. Such humility can go a long way toward earning credibility and trust with an audience. Your readers will know from the beginning that you are a reasonable writer, and they will trust your argument as a result. For example, in the following concessionary statement, the writer advocates for stricter gun control laws, but admits it will not solve all of our problems with crime:

Although tougher gun control laws are a powerful first step in decreasing violence in our streets, such legislation alone cannot end these problems since guns are not the only problem that we face.

Such a concession will be welcome by those who might disagree with this writer's argument in the first place. To effectively persuade their readers, writers need to be modest in their goals and humble in their approach to get readers to listen to the ideas. The following are some useful phrases of concession:

- Although...
- Granted that...
- Of course...
- Still...
- Though...
- Yet...

For more examples of phrases of concession, see *They Say, I Say: Moves that Matter in Academic Writing* in the **Additional Resources** section at the back of this book.

Bias in Writing

Everyone has various biases on any number of topics. For example, you might have a bias toward wearing black instead of brightly coloured clothes, or wearing jeans rather than formal wear. You might be biased toward working at night rather than in the morning, or working by deadlines rather than getting tasks done in advance. These examples identify minor biases, but they still indicate preferences and opinions.

Bias and angles can easily appear even through the smallest words you choose to use in your writing. Choosing each word carefully is even more significant in a persuasive paper because, as already mentioned, you want your reader to view your presentation of ideas as logical and not just a tirade. Using language precisely, incorporating credible evidence, and acknowledging you have a possible bias will help you present a well-rounded and developed argument.

Handling bias in writing and in daily life can be a useful skill. It will allow you to articulate your own points of view while also defending yourself against unreasonable points of view. The ideal in persuasive writing is to let your reader know your bias, but do not let that bias blind you to the primary components of good argumentation: sound, thoughtful evidence and a respectful and reasonable address of opposing sides.

- **The strength of a personal bias** is that it can motivate you to construct a strong argument. If you are invested in the topic, you are more likely to care about the piece of writing. Similarly, the more you care, the more time and effort you are apt to put forth and the better the final product will be.
- **The weakness of personal bias** is that it can take over the essay—when, for example, you neglect opposing ideas, exaggerate your points, or repeatedly insert yourself ahead of the subject by using *I* too often. Being aware of these pitfalls will help you avoid them.

The Use of I in Writing

The use of *I* in writing is often a topic of debate, and the acceptance of it varies from instructor to instructor. It is difficult to predict the preferences for all your present and future instructors, but consider the effects it can potentially have on your writing.

Be mindful of the use of *I* in your writing because it can detract from your argument for three primary reasons:

1. Excessive repetition of any word will eventually catch the reader's attention—and usually not in a good way. The use of *I* is no different.
2. Using *I* is personal and suggests that your argument is personally biased as well. If you are trying to appeal to or relate to a broad audience, it can be beneficial to remove overt personal bias from your writing, and more of that bias is invoked when you use personal pronouns.
3. The insertion of *I* into a sentence alters not only the way a sentence might sound but also the composition of the sentence itself. *I* is often the subject of a sentence. If the subject of the essay is supposed to be, say, smoking, then by inserting yourself into the sentence, you are effectively displacing the subject of the essay into a secondary position. In the following example, the subject of the sentence is bolded:

Smoking is bad. vs **I** think smoking is bad.

In the first sentence, the rightful subject, *smoking*, is in the subject position in the sentence. In the second sentence, the insertion of *I* and *think* replaces *smoking* as the subject, which draws attention to *I* and away from the topic that is supposed to be discussed. Remember to keep the message (the subject) and the messenger (the writer) separate. You can use **Checklist Developing Sound Arguments** (below), as you work on your persuasive essay.

Checklist Developing Sound Arguments

Does my essay contain the following elements?

- An engaging introduction

- A reasonable, specific thesis that is able to be supported by evidence
- A varied range of evidence from credible sources
- Respectful acknowledgment and explanation of opposing ideas
- A style and tone of language that is appropriate for the subject and audience
- Acknowledgment of the argument's limits
- A conclusion that will adequately summarize the essay and reinforce the thesis

Tip: The word *prove* is frequently used in the discussion of persuasive writing. Writers may claim that one piece of evidence or another proves the argument, but proving an argument is often not possible. No evidence proves a debatable topic one way or the other; that is why the topic is debatable. Facts can be proved, but opinions can only be supported, explained, and persuaded.

Argument: A Crash Course in Philosophy

When students think of argument, they often think of it in terms of conflict and, therefore, as something unpleasant and to be avoided. But here's the thing: conflict itself is not inherently bad; it's healthy and normal for people to have differences of opinion. Conflict gets a bad rep because many people don't know how to handle or deal with it appropriately, and so conversations de-evolve into arguments (in the combative sense of the word).

In an academic context, arguing – or debating – is how new and interesting ideas emerge. You may find that some of your professors may seem combative when they debate ideas or points in a classroom. This is because many of your professors have been trained to separate personal feelings from academic argument. In other words, because academia thrives on debating, your professors develop a thick skin and focus on weighing the merit of ideas without taking critiques to heart. Academic argument is about putting *ideas* under scrutiny – not the *arguer*.

In order to create solid academic arguments that will withstand rigorous academic debate, it's important that several key elements be incorporated. While we will cover different models of essay writing later, let's first consider how *arguments* (the building blocks of a thesis and an essay) are created.

Logic and the Parts of an Argument

Premises

An argument is first and foremost made up by **premises** – statements that are either **true or false** (yes or no) and **present a claim**. These statements are typically short in nature:

All birds can fly. (False premise – penguins and chickens cannot fly)

Canada has ten provinces and three territories. (True premise)

Rajdeep is a student at Sheridan College. (True premise)

Premises can be used alongside each other to help build an argument. When we have multiple premises working together, we can form **conclusions** based upon that information.

Conclusions

Also known as a *sequitur* (Latin to mean “it follows”). In this context, we are not talking about a *concluding paragraph* in an essay (that’s something that we cover later in Chapter 6); rather, **conclusions** are the main point that we are meant to take away from an argument or what the arguer is trying to prove. Conclusions are derived from the premises. The easiest way to recognize a conclusion is to ask yourself two questions:

1. Does it make sense if I put the word *therefore* in front of the statement? The word *therefore* denotes a relationship, and using it makes sense if you’ve given enough information in the premise(s)
2. Is this the major point that the argument is trying to make? Does it answer the main question or purpose?

We use argument all of the time to reason and form conclusions about the world around us. Imagine that you are hosting a party and you plan to serve Indian food. With the exception of one guest – Tanisha – you know that everyone else attending likes Indian food. With a bit of information and some reasoning, you can use logical argument to form a conclusion about whether or not Tanisha will eat the Indian food that you plan to serve:

Premise 1: Tanisha likes spicy food.

Premise 2: Tanisha has travelled to many countries.

Premise 3: Tanisha likes trying new things.

Conclusion: Therefore, Tanisha probably likes Indian food.

In this case, the main purpose is to determine if Tanisha will eat Indian food. Our conclusion meets that requirement. It also makes sense to put *therefore* in front of the statement because we have enough information in the premises to support the conclusion.

While this may be a rather simplistic example (arguments can become far more complex), the point here is to see how

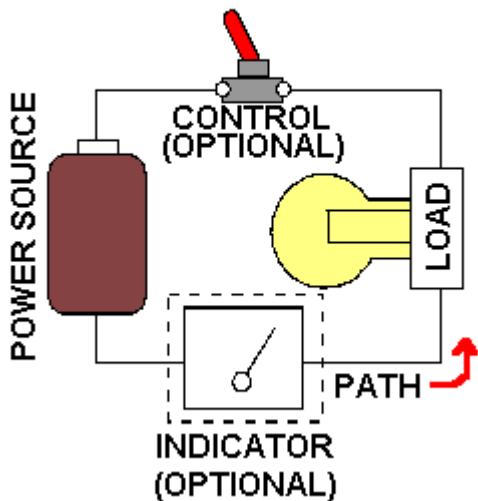
premises can be combined together to help us arrive at conclusions. This process does sometimes involve us building some mental connections to link the premises together with the conclusion; these “leaps in logic” are called **inferences**.

Inferences

An **inference** is the connections that we make between premises to reach a conclusion. Think about argumentative form like a basic electrical circuit. You need a source of **power** (**premise**) to turn on a load, like a **lightbulb** (**conclusion**, or end result). But for connection to be made between the two, you need **conductors** (**inferences**), like wire, to close the circuit so that **electricity** (**logic**) can flow. In other words, **inferences** help the **logic** flow between the **premises** and **conclusions**. Once you have the circuit closed successfully, you have what we call a **sound argument** (more on sound arguments later).

It's important to note that inferences are not necessary in every argument. To modify the earlier analogy, some arguments are simple enough that we can simply attach the battery directly to the lightbulb (these are typically called **deductive arguments**, which we cover later in this chapter). However, in such a case, the circuit becomes more restricted in what it can do, which limits your ability and opportunity to make more complex circuits and systems. The same holds true for arguments: you *can* make them without inferences, but they will likely be more contextual and less widely-applicable in nature. Inferences – the conductors – allow you to move parts of the circuit around and do new and interesting things.

SIMPLE CIRCUIT



Typically, your brain will fill in inferences on its own to “close the circuit,” which can make identifying inferences tricky. One helpful way can be to consider the *if/then* model, which looks something like this:

Premise 1: Tanisha likes spicy food.

Premise 2: Tanisha has travelled to many countries.

Premise 3: Tanisha likes trying new things.

***Inference 1:** If Tanisha has travelled to many countries and likes to try new things, then she has probably eaten spicy food abroad.*

***Conclusion:** Therefore, Tanisha probably likes Indian food.*

It is common to have several premises, inferences, and even conclusions, depending on how complex your argument and essay are. The more premises and inferences that you have, the more intricate your conclusion(s) and argument will

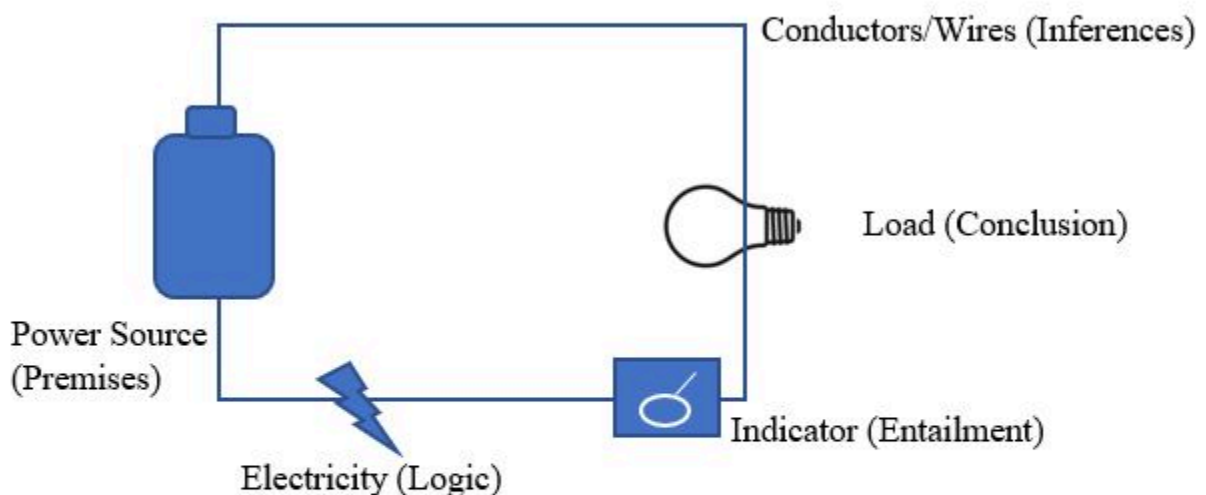
be. When identifying them, we typically number them, as you can see in aforementioned example (Premise 1, Premise 2, Premise 3, Inference 1, Conclusion 1).

Entailment

Entailment is the line of reasoning that is being used in an argument, or the logical progression between the premises, inferences (if present), and conclusions. It can also be thought of as a series of logical steps or consequences as you move to each new idea.

To return to the circuit metaphor, **entailment** would be the **fault indicator** in the circuit – its purpose is to let us know if there's a problem with how the **electricity** (the **logic**) is moving through the circuit. Entailment helps us to understand if the circuit is going to experience problems from a lack of power (false or not enough **premises**), faulty wires (poor **inferences**), or too much/little voltage for the load (unsupported or unsound **conclusions**).

THE ARGUMENTATIVE CIRCUIT



Source: J. Warkentin (2020)

Truth versus Validity

Consider the concept of *truth* for a moment. Many people think of this concept in a sense of *The Truth* – that is, the notion of *truth* as the “right” or “correct” understanding of something. We demand that children tell “The Truth” very often, which means that we want them to recount events or details both accurately and factually.

However, in the world of argument, our understandings of *truth* can shift around quite a bit. If you’ve ever disagreed with someone, you will know how tough it can be to determine *truth*. You may hear people talk about “speaking one’s truth” (their lived experience). Consider the following quotation, which encapsulates the tension between truth and argument:

Your opinion is your opinion, your perception is your perception—do not confuse them with “facts” or “truth”. Wars have been fought and millions have been killed because of the inability of men to understand the idea that EVERYBODY has a different viewpoint. – John Moore

In the Moore quotation above, he speaks about *truth* in the framework of **objective truth** – that is, an understanding of truth that rests upon facts and social consensus, such as the truth that the Earth is subject to gravitational forces. From a philosophical standpoint, we can also consider **subjective truths** (a “truth” based upon one’s individual sense and perception of reality). You might encounter some people who argue that there is no such thing as an objective truth because every experience must be filtered through a personal lens and we cannot know if everyone perceives certain “givens” the same way.

For example, let’s look at a classic internet debate: what colour is this dress?



Known infamously on the internet as *The Dress*, some people see the image in black and blue, while others see white and gold. A fierce debate broke out online, and the “truth” of what people are seeing is subjective and based upon many factors, including screen resolution, angle, and perception.

But you could take this point a step further – what if the person viewing the dress is colour blind, and they see different colour combinations all together? Is that person’s reality – their subjective truth – somehow less valid because it’s not what other people see?

The concept of *truth* is incredibly complex. In fact, comedian Stephen Colbert actually tackled this concept in his pilot episode of *The Colbert Report* when his “The Word” segment focused on *truthiness*. In this particular case, [truthiness is defined](#) as: “the quality of seeming to be true according to one’s intuition, opinion, or perception without regard to logic, factual evidence, or the like.” If you want to go really [meta](#), Colbert made up a word – *truthiness* – and it became so realized in the world that it became a real (or true) word because enough people reached consensus upon the validity and meaning of the word. In other words, *truth* is simply agreed upon reality.

Exercise

Consider the following excerpt from the American [Declaration of Independence](#) (July 4, 1776). Does the text refer to **objective** or **subjective truths**? What are the larger social and political arguments related to the concept of *truth* and how it is being employed here?

“We hold these **truths** to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed, by their Creator, with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty, and the pursuit of Happiness.

That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles, and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness.

Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shewn, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object, evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future security.”

To consider validity using the concepts that we have discussed so far in this chapter, an argument is said to be **valid** when the [conclusion](#) accurately follows the [entailment](#) and [logic](#) of the [premises](#) and [inferences](#). An argument can be *valid* without being *true*. If the argument is both *valid and true*, we say that the argument is **sound**.

The following image helps to explain the difference between these two concepts:

Truth vs Validity More Information Online WWW.DIFFERENCEBETWEEN.COM		
	Truth	Validity
DEFINITION	Truth is a property of premises and conclusions	Validity is a property of arguments
DETERMINATION	The truth of a premise or a conclusion is determined by various factors such as common sense, personal experience, investigation, etc.	An argument is valid when the conclusion follows logically from the premises

An example would be helpful here to demonstrate the differences:

All men are mortal. – *true premise*

Socrates is a man. – *true premise*

Therefore, Socrates is mortal. – *valid and true conclusion*

This argument is sound because the conclusion is both **valid** (the entailment is consistent) and **true** (it makes sense and the premises are accurate). However, take a look at what happens when the entailment is valid, but the premises are not true:

All men are immortal. – false premise

Socrates is a man. – true premise

Therefore, Socrates is immortal. – valid but false conclusion

In this instance, the conclusion is **valid** but **untrue**. Based upon our (unsound) entailment, one would conclude that Socrates is immortal (which is valid, based upon the entailment or line of reasoning). However, we know that men are mortal, not *immortal*, so the false premise has led us to a false (or untrue) conclusion.

Here is an example of what happens when the premises and entailment fail or are **unsound**:

All cups are red. – false premise

Socrates is red. – false premise

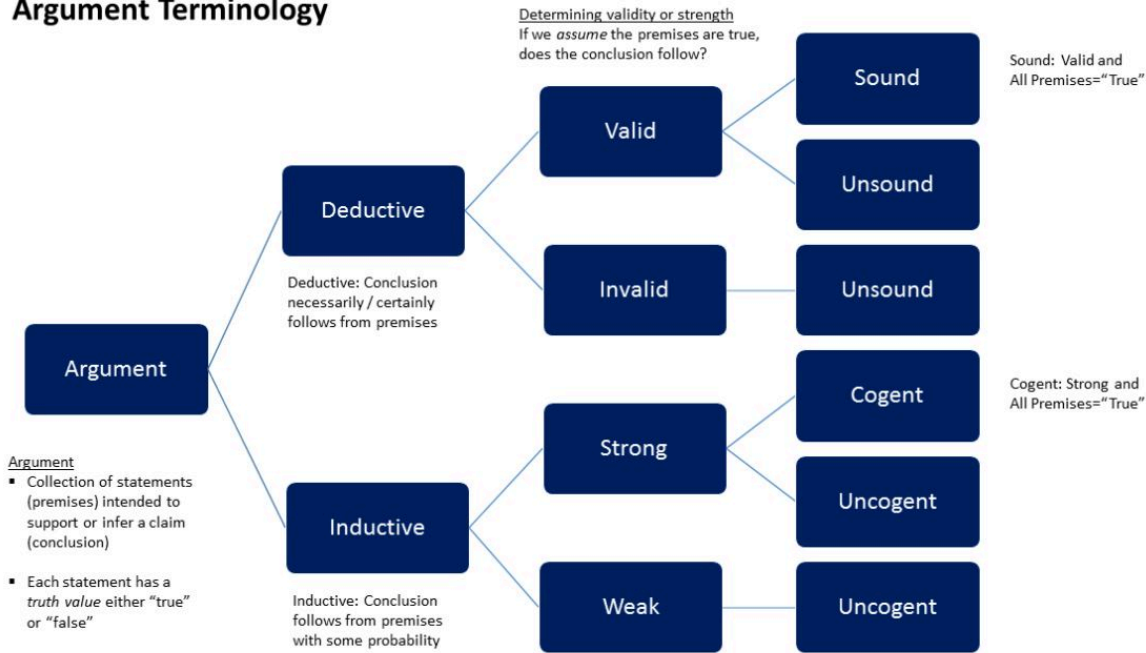
Therefore, Socrates is a turkey – invalid, false conclusion

It is worth noting that if you have a false premise, you will automatically have a false (or untrue) conclusion, thereby making the argument unsound.

Forms of Reasoning

Using the building blocks of argument – premises, inferences, and conclusions – we can create different **forms of reasoning** or types of argument. We will start with **deductive arguments** because they build upon the previous discussion of truth and validity.

Argument Terminology



Deductive Argument

A **deductive argument** is one that is more objective in nature. In general terms, deductive reasoning involves using a given set of facts or data to deduce other facts through logical reasoning. We can easily determine objective truth in the premises and conclusion based upon common sense, consensus, and facts. Consider the example of Socrates from the previous section:

All men are mortal. – true premise

Socrates is a man. – true premise

Therefore, Socrates is mortal. – valid and true conclusion

Applying the deduction method on the general rule "all humans are mortal" (called a **major premise**) in the specific situation "Socrates is human" (called a **minor premise**), the conclusion can be drawn that "Socrates is mortal". This deductive argument is an example of an argument where you would not need an inference (or you could attach the lightbulb directly to the battery). Notice that deductive reasoning provides no new information; it only rearranges information that is already known into a new statement or truth. Deductive reasoning can be used to prove that these new facts are true or that certain facts continue to be true.

It is important to note that deductive reasoning does not leave much room for qualifiers, variables, or interpretation, particularly in **sylogisms** (definition below). Consider the following argument:

All dogs are animals.

All animals have four legs.

Therefore, dogs have four legs.

This is a valid and true conclusion; however, it is possible for a dog to experience a birth deformity and have fewer than four legs. It's also possible for a dog to have a leg amputated. Deductive argument focuses on *the most typical and common occurrence/state of a premise*, which is one of the large limitations to this form of reasoning – it doesn't accommodate exceptions to the rule or outlying circumstances.

Syllogism

Deductive arguments often contain **syllogisms**: “an instance of a form of reasoning in which a conclusion is drawn (whether validly or not) from two given or assumed propositions (premises), each of which shares a term with the conclusion, and share a common or middle term not present in the conclusion” (Oxford, *Syllogism*).

The Socrates and Animal examples above are syllogisms.

Student Tip

If you're writing an argumentative essay and feel like you have little to say on the topic, it is possible that you have set up a deductive argument when you really need to have an *inductive argument* (see next section). Because deductive arguments leave little room for debate or interpretation – but *are still arguments* – this is a common writing trap for students to encounter. Your thesis statement or essay may *look* like an argumentative essay, but if you have a deductive thesis, it will read more like a research report or expository essay; this error will lead you to miss the mark in terms of assignment requirements and evaluation.

Deductive arguments are more helpful when you are less likely to be debating or arguing a position and focusing more on analyzing existing data and situations. For more information, see **Chapter 5**.

Inductive Argument

While deductive argument may be restricted in its ability to bring in new ideas or debates about variables on a given position, **inductive argument** allows the arguer to speculate, look at patterns/trends, and argue for new positions or interpretations of an issue or topic. **Inductive reasoning** involves looking for a pattern or a trend and then generalizing it. When you generalize or extrapolate the information, you cannot know for certain that the trend will continue or be consistent with past results, but you assume that it will. For this reason, inductive reasoning and arguments can never be 100% true or even agreed upon fully – biases, paradigms, and other factors will always ensure that there will be a contingent of people that disagree with the arguer’s position or conclusion. This is why inductive arguments are required to provide ample **proof** in the form of **evidence** (see Chapter 3); since we cannot determine objective truth about inductive premises (as we can with deductive premises), we must rely on other sources of information to support the premises and inferences that are made in the pursuit of a conclusion.

Another difference between deductive and inductive arguments is that while deductive arguments tend to be more factual and objective in nature, inductive arguments tend to rely on the **subjective judgments and positions** of both the arguer and the reader. The subjective nature of inductive reasoning is why argumentative essays require the arguer to also address the opposing viewpoints (which we will discuss in-depth later in Chapter 6) and clearly articulate and support claims with evidence.

Because the truth is objective and easier to discern in deductive arguments, it is less common to encounter inferences in that form of reasoning. However, the subjective nature of inductive argument typically requires that the arguer use inferences in order to reach a conclusion. The ability to speculate about trends and argue about what we should think or should do in a give context relies upon arguers and audiences alike being able to infer relationships/connections between points being made, evidence being presented, and the conclusions being drawn.

INDUCTIVE reasoning

VS

DEDUCTIVE reasoning

No matter how unrealistic that sounds, in many fields, such as science and law, "proof" simply doesn't exist; there can only be facts and evidence that lead you to certain conclusions.

INDUCTIVE REASONING

- Someone who uses INDUCTIVE reasoning makes **specific observations** and **then draws a general conclusion**.
- When you're using inductive reasoning, correct observations won't necessarily lead you to a correct general conclusion.

EXAMPLES

1. Every quiz has been easy. Therefore, the test will be easy.
2. The teacher used PPT in the last few classes. Therefore, the teacher will use PPT tomorrow.



DEDUCTIVE REASONING

- DEDUCTIVE reasoning is a **specific conclusion follows a general theory**.
- When you're using deductive reasoning, your conclusion will be correct if all the statements you say is correct.

EXAMPLES

1. All students in this class play guitar.
Sam is a student of this class.
--> Therefore, Sam plays guitar.
2. At the conference, all the people present are thirty or older.
Maria is in the room.
--> Therefore, Maria is at least thirty.

Abductive Argument

Take a moment to think about the argument we examined about Tanisha and the Indian food earlier in this chapter. That particular form of argument was an **abductive argument**. Abductive reasoning and arguments are similar to the inductive style; however, rather than looking at concrete and predictive patterns or trends, abductive reasoning is a form of *informed and educated guessing*. The conclusions drawn in abductive arguments are based upon probabilities and extrapolations from related information.

Abductive reasoning is something that people use all of the time in day-to-day life. When something doesn't happen as we would expect it to – perhaps a friend is late to a meeting and we don't know why – we consider what scenarios are likely based upon any information that we have. If your friend is often late to things, you might conclude that this is nothing out of the ordinary; however, if your friend is typically *early* to meetings, then abductive reasoning might lead you to conclude that something is wrong and that you should be concerned.

Abductive reasoning also depends on **Occam's Razor** – a theory that the simplest explanation that accounts for all variables and criteria is likely the answer. In other words, the most plausible or likely conclusion is probably the correct conclusion. In the argument about Tanisha and the Indian food, we considered certain factors about her lifestyle and preferences in order to make an educated guess that she would *probably* like Indian food. Here is another example:

Major premise: The cookie jar is filled with chocolate chip cookies.

Minor premise: Arshpreet has a chocolate chip cookie in his hand.

Conclusion: The cookie in Arshpreet's hand was taken out of the jar.

By using abductive reasoning, we can argue that the cookie that Arshpreet is holding is from the same cookie jar, but we cannot prove that definitively without more information or evidence. The cookie could have been given to Arshpreet by someone else, or maybe he brought it from home; however, given what we know about the situation and context, this seems unlikely. It is the *more likely* scenario that Arshpreet took a cookie from the jar. This is abductive logic.

It is common to combine different forms of logical reasoning into essays or assignments at the post-secondary level. Depending on the nature of your topic, your assignment might require you to use different approaches to reasoning to help you come to new conclusions or form new opinions. Make sure to follow the instructions for your assignments, but also don't be afraid to try out different strategies for constructing your arguments. Abductive arguments have the potential to be a great foundation for building deductive and inductive arguments (see the table below).



Inference	Process	Relationship to Theory	Examples based on this approach
<i>Abduction</i>	Creates tentative explanations to make sense of observations for which there is no appropriate explanation or rule in the existing store of knowledge	Does not start with explanations but instead links things together to generate an order that fits the surprising facts – the beginning of theory-building	Lean start up, grounded theory, design thinking, constructive design research, prototyping
Having developed a guess, explore the consequences via deduction			
<i>Deduction</i>	Taking a general rule and seeing what follows in particular cases	Top down: Explores the necessary consequences of a rule	Randomized control trials, experiments in the natural and physical sciences
Now make observations to see if the rule and the consequences hold via induction			
<i>Induction</i>	Looking across cases and data to produce a rule or pattern	Ground up: Has a theory in mind and seek confirmation across cases	Surveys, cases, interviews

One of the weakness of abductive arguments is that they are speculative and can lead to a false conclusion that undermines the larger argument. The risk of a false conclusion is also why we try to avoid incorporating hypothetical scenarios as evidence when presenting an argument – speculative or hypothetical scenarios and arguments can lead to errors in logic or an argument that we call **fallacies**.

Argument and Fallacies

A **fallacy is a defect in your argument**, and can occur in your assignment in a couple of ways:

1. You have an error in the logical reasoning. This is called a **Formal Fallacy**, which means there is an error in the **deductive structure** of your argument. For example, the argument may have false premises, inferences, conclusions, or the entailment doesn't work.
2. You make a move in your argument that is considered to be "bad form" or incorrect by rhetorical standards. This is called an **Informal Fallacy**, which means that there is an error in the **content** of your argument. For example, you might appeal to an audience's emotions (appeal to pathos) in a context that should be using an appeal to logos.

While arguments can contain fallacies and still be valid, fallacies will typically compromise the truth of the argument and thus, the strength of your position.

There are far too many fallacies to name them all here, so we will cover some of the most common ones in order to demonstrate how fallacies can impact your arguments:

Fallacy	Definition	Example
Dicto Simpliciter (Sweeping Generalization; Stereotyping)	Argument based on unqualified generalization	Women are, on average, not as strong as men and less able to carry a gun. Therefore, women can't pull their weight in a military unit.
Hasty Generalization	Argument based on limited or biased sample to reach conclusion; leads to faulty conclusion	I met some children from Canada yesterday who were very polite. I think all Canadian children must be polite.
Post hoc, ergo propter hoc	Assumes that A caused B simply because A happened prior to B. Often superstitions arise from Post hoc logic.	There was no appreciable crime related to drugs when they were legal. Crime rate has increased since they have been made illegal. Therefore, drugs should be legal since legalization would improve the "quality of life" in Canada.
Contradictory Premises	The two premises contradict; therefore, the logic is faulty. This fallacy is popular in the form of challenging questions because questions with contradictory premises are misleading	Into what shape would a round square fit? If an object is all black and all white at the same time, what colour is it?
Ad Misericordiam (appeal for sympathy)	Someone tries to win support for their argument or idea by exploiting their opponent's feelings of pity or guilt. Commonly known as a guilt trip.	Oh, officer, there's no reason to give me a traffic ticket for going too fast – I was just on my way to the hospital to see my wife, who is in serious condition, to tell her that I lost my job and the car will be repossessed.
False Analogy	In false analogies, though A and B may be similar in one aspect (such as colour), they may not both share property X (eg. Size)	Apples and oranges are the same thing – they're both round fruit.
Hypothesis Contrary to Fact	This fallacy consists of offering a poorly supported claim about what might have happened in the past or future if circumstances or conditions were other than what they actually were or are. This fallacy also involves treating hypothetical situations as if they were fact	In a lab, you conclude that plants give off carbon dioxide and use oxygen; therefore carbon dioxide is a byproduct of photosynthesis. (This is inverse – plants give off oxygen).
Poisoning the Well	Where adverse information about a target is pre-emptively presented to an audience with the intention of discrediting or ridiculing everything that the target person is about to say.	He has been proven to be a liar numerous times, so don't believe anything that he tells you.

Equivocation (Circular Logic)	Using the same term with different meanings	Hot dogs are better than nothing. There's nothing better than steak. So hot dogs are better than steak. An aspirin will make noisy children go away because noisy children are a headache and aspirin makes headaches go away.
Non sequitur ("it does not follow")	The conclusion does not follow the argument; entailment is incorrect; no direct relationship	Bill lives in a large building, so his apartment must be large.
Begging the Question	Assumes that something is true when it is in need of proof	We must have a death penalty to discourage violent crime (makes the assumption that the death penalty will discourage crime)
Ignoring the Question (Red Herring)	Ignores the real issue by the use of distracting information; an irrelevant response	Q: Did the president have an affair? A: He's very busy with global peace talks at the moment, and has no time for silly accusations.
Faulty Dilemma (Either/Or Reasoning)	All options are not taken into consideration in the solution posed by the major premise	Atheism is the only alternative to Fundamentalism. Being a traitor is the only alternative to being a loud patriot.
Ad hominem ("to the person")	Ignores the real issue by turning attention to an individual; attacks someone personally, rather than their argument	Von Daniken's books about ancient astronauts are worthless because he is a convicted forger and embezzler. (Which is true, but that's not why they're worthless)
Straw Man	A fallacy where one gives the impression that they are refuting an opponent's argument, but really are refuting an argument that was NOT presented by that opponent. Putting words into someone's mouth.	Opposing argument: Teens should be taught about contraception methods so they can practice safe sex should they choose to have intercourse. Straw man argument: Proponents of sex education want to give kids license to have sex with no consequences.

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Key Terms and Concepts

- Rhetorical Appeals
- Ethos
- Pathos
- Logos
- Bias
- Premise
- Conclusion
- Inference
- Soundness (Sound Argument)
- Entailment
- Objective Truth
- Subjective Truth
- Validity
- Deductive Argument
- Syllogism
- Inductive Argument
- Abductive Argument
- Formal Fallacies
- Informal Fallacies

3. Using Evidence Effectively

Chapter 3 Content Summary:

- Evaluating Research Sources
- Finding, Classifying, and Using Research Sources
- Using Evidence
- Sheridan's Library and Learning Services

Evaluating Research Resources

As you gather sources, you will need to examine them with a critical eye. Smart researchers continually ask themselves two questions: “Is this source relevant to my purpose?” and “Is this source reliable?” The first question will help you avoid wasting valuable time reading sources that stray too far from your specific topic and research questions. The second question will help you find accurate, trustworthy sources.

The different types of sources you will consult are written for distinct purposes and with different audiences in mind. This accounts for other differences, such as the following:

- How thoroughly the writers cover a given topic
- How carefully the writers research and document facts
- How editors review the work
- What biases or agendas affect the content.

A journal article written for an academic audience for the purpose of expanding scholarship in a given field will take an approach quite different from a magazine feature written to inform a general audience. Textbooks, hard news articles, and websites approach a subject from different angles as well. To some extent, the type of source provides clues about its overall depth and reliability. The *Source Rankings* table below ranks different source types in an overview to help demonstrate how the quality of a source is determined:

Source Rankings

High-Quality Sources

These sources provide the most in-depth information. They are researched and written by subject matter experts and are carefully reviewed.

- Scholarly books and articles in scholarly journals
- Trade books and magazines geared toward an educated general audience, such as *Police Chief magazine*, *Canadian Paramedicine*, or *Harvard Business Review*
- Government documents, such as books, reports, and web pages
- Documents posted online by reputable organizations, such as universities and research institutes
- Textbooks and reference books, which are usually reliable but may not cover a topic in great depth

Varied-Quality Sources

These sources are often useful. However, they do not cover subjects in as much depth as high-quality sources, and they are not always rigorously researched and reviewed. Some, such as popular magazine articles or company brochures, may be written to market a product or a cause. ****Use these sources with caution.****

- News stories and feature articles (print or online) from reputable newspapers, magazines, or organizations, such as *The Economist* or the Canadian Broadcasting Corporation
- Popular magazine articles, which may or may not be carefully researched and fact checked
- Documents published by businesses and nonprofit organizations

Questionable Sources

These sources are often written primarily to attract a large readership or present the author's opinions and are not subject to careful review. ****Avoid using these sources for secondary evidence!****

- Loosely regulated or unregulated media content, such as Internet discussion boards, blogs, free online encyclopedias, talk radio shows, television news shows with obvious political biases, personal websites, and chat rooms
-

Tip: Free online encyclopedias and wikis may seem like a great source of information. They usually appear among the first few results of a web search. They cover thousands of topics, and many articles use an informal, straightforward writing style. Unfortunately, these sites have no control system for researching, writing, and reviewing articles. Instead, they rely on a community of users to police themselves. At best, these sites can be a starting point for finding other, more trustworthy sources. *Never use them as final sources.*

Understanding Source Rankings: Questions to Ask When Assessing a Source

1. Is the source reliable?

All sources of information are not created equal. Sources can vary greatly in terms of how carefully they are researched, written, edited, and reviewed for accuracy. Common sense will help you identify obviously questionable sources, such as tabloids that feature tales of alien abductions, or personal websites with glaring typos. Sometimes, however, a source's **reliability**—or lack of it—is not so obvious.

To evaluate your research sources, you will use critical thinking skills consciously and deliberately. You will consider criteria such as the type of source, its intended purpose and audience, the author's qualifications, the publication's reputation, any indications of bias or hidden agendas, how current the source is, and the overall quality of the writing, thinking, and design.

2. Is it credible/reputable?

Even when you are using a type of source that is generally reliable, you will still need to evaluate the author's credibility and the publication itself on an individual basis. To examine the author's **credibility**—that is, how much you can believe of what the author has to say—examine his or her academic and professional credentials. What career experience or academic background does the author have that qualifies them to write about this topic?

Keep in mind that expertise in one field is no guarantee of expertise in another, unrelated area. For instance, an author may have an advanced degree in physiology, but this credential is not a valid qualification for writing about psychology. Check all authorial credentials carefully.

Just as important as the author's credibility is the publication's overall reputability. **Reputability** refers to a source's standing and reputation as a respectable, reliable source of information. An established and well-known newspaper, such as the *Globe and Mail* or the *New York Times*, is (usually) more reputable than a college newspaper put out by comparatively inexperienced students. A website that is maintained by a well-known, respected organization and is regularly updated is more reputable than one created by an unknown author or group.

If you are using articles from scholarly journals, you can check databases that keep count of how many times each article has been cited in other articles. This can give you a rough indication of the article's quality or, at the very least, of its influence and reputation among other scholars.

3. Are there biases or hidden agendas?

Whenever you consult a source, always think carefully about the author's purpose in presenting the information. Few sources present facts completely objectively. In some cases, the source's content and tone are significantly influenced by biases or hidden agendas.

Bias refers to favouritism or prejudice towards something. For instance, an author may be biased against a certain political party and present information in a way that subtly—or not so subtly—makes that organization look bad. Bias can lead an author to present facts selectively, edit quotations to misrepresent someone's words, distort information, and skew research (for example, by having a small sample size for a research study that is not representative of a larger group of subjects).

Note that not all biases are bad – in fact, in hard-core academic arguments, we embrace our biases as a useful tool as they help us to come up with points to support our position. We all have biases that have been influenced and constructed by our **paradigms** – thought patterns, experiences, and beliefs that constitute how we view the world and our place within it. If you are writing a paper on the benefits of increased social housing, then you are likely going to demonstrate a bias in favour of social housing. In some cases, the nature of your topic will make biases inescapable – the goal is to *acknowledge* and *minimize* our biases by being conscious of our use of language, the evidence we use, how we represent alternative positions or arguments, and by making sure to represent points of view as fairly as possible.

Hidden agendas are goals that are not immediately obvious but influence how an author presents the facts. Hidden agendas typically represent the negative types of biases for which we want to watch out. For instance, an article about the role of beef in a healthy diet would be questionable if it were written by a representative of the beef industry—or by the president of an animal rights organization. In both cases, the author would likely have a hidden agenda and would be biased by that agenda when writing for an audience.

4. Is the source relevant?

At this point in your research process, you may have identified dozens of potential sources. It is easy for writers to get so caught up in checking out books and printing out articles that they forget to ask themselves how they will use these resources in their research. Now is a good time to get a little ruthless. Reading and taking notes takes time and energy, so you will want to focus on the most relevant sources.

To weed through your stack of books and articles, skim their contents. Read quickly with your research questions and subtopics in mind. The table below, *Tips for Skimming Books and Articles*, explains how to skim research to get a quick sense of what topics are covered. If a book or article is not especially relevant, put it aside. You can always come back to it later if you need to.

Tips for Skimming Books and Articles

Tips for Skimming Books

- Read the dust jacket and table of contents for a broad overview of the topics covered.
- Use the index to locate more specific topics and see how thoroughly they are covered.
- Flip through the book and look for subtitles or key terms that correspond to your research.

Tips for Skimming Articles

- Skim the introduction and conclusion for summary material.
 - Skim through subheadings and text features such as sidebars.
 - Look for keywords related to your topic.
 - Journal articles often begin with an abstract or summary of the contents.
 - Read it to determine the article's relevance to your research.
-

5. Is the source current?

Depending on the topic, sources may become outdated relatively soon after publication, or they may remain useful for years. The age of a source you can use will depend on your research topic and approach. For example, were you to be investigating current medical developments for diabetes, be sure to seek out sources that are current, or up to date. If you were examining the *history* of diabetes medical developments, you would be looking for sources as far back as you could find.

Timeliness – or the currency of a source – is a complicated issue for researchers, particularly with the internet. For instance, online social networking sites have evolved rapidly over the past few years. An article published in 2002 about this topic will not provide current information. On the other hand, a research paper on elementary education practices might refer to studies published decades ago by influential child psychologists.

When using websites for research, check to see when the site was last updated. Many sites publish this information on the homepage, and some, such as news sites, are updated daily or weekly. Many nonfunctioning links are a sign that a website is not regularly updated. Do not be afraid to ask your instructor for suggestions if you find that many of your most relevant sources are not especially reliable—or that the most reliable sources are not relevant.

Doing a Research Source Assessment

When you evaluate a source, you will consider the criteria previously discussed as well as your overall impressions of its quality. Read carefully, and notice how well the author presents and supports his or her statements. Stay actively engaged—do not simply accept an author's words as truth. Ask questions to determine each source's value.

The CRAAP Test

An easy way to evaluate sources is by using the CRAAP Test. In other words, consider the following criteria:

CURRENCY

- How current is the information? Is the information current enough for YOUR topic?

- When was the source published, created or updated?

RELEVANCY

- Is the information relevant to your topic?
- Who is the target audience for this source. Children? Academics? Students? Scientists?

AUTHORITY

- Who created the source or who is the author? Is it an individual, a corporation, an organization or association?
- What are the credentials of the author? Do they have PhD? Experience in the field? Do they have a good reputation?

ACCURACY

- Are sources or references given to support the information or evidence provided?
- Are there spelling or grammar errors?
- Can you find similar or the same information in other credible sources?

PURPOSE

- Is the information provided factual only, or is it opinion or biased?
- Is the source trying to sell you something, or persuade you to a particular point of view?

Writing at Work

The critical thinking skills you use to evaluate research sources as a student are equally valuable when you conduct research on the job. If you follow certain periodicals or websites, you have probably identified publications that consistently provide reliable information. Reading blogs and online discussion groups is a great way to identify new trends and hot topics in a particular field, but these sources should not be used for substantial research.

Self-Practice Exercise

Use a search engine to conduct a web search on your topic. Refer to the tips provided earlier to help you streamline your search. Evaluate your search results critically based on the criteria you have learned. Identify and bookmark one or more websites that are reliable, reputable, and likely to be useful in your research.

Finding, Classifying, and Using Research Sources

Locating Useful Resources

When you chose a topic and have determined your research question(s), you have conducted preliminary research to stimulate your thinking. You may even have identified a few potential sources. Now it is time to conduct a more focused, systematic search for informative **primary** and **secondary sources**.

Writers classify research resources in two categories: primary sources and secondary sources. **Primary sources** are direct, firsthand sources of information or data from a particular event or context. For example, if you were writing a paper about freedom of religion in Canada, the text of the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms would be a primary source.

Other primary sources include the following:

- Research articles
- Literary texts
- Historical documents such as diaries or letters
- Autobiographies or other personal accounts

Secondary sources discuss, interpret, analyze, consolidate, or otherwise re-work information from primary sources. They also tell you what research has already been conducted on your topic and what areas/conclusions have been deemed important by that scholarly community. In researching a paper about freedom of religion, you might read articles about legal cases that involved freedom of religion, or editorials expressing commentary on freedom of religion. These would be considered secondary sources because they are one step removed from the primary source of information.

The following are examples of secondary sources:

- Magazine articles
- Biographical books

- Literary and scientific reviews
- Television documentaries

Your topic and purpose determine whether you must cite both primary and secondary sources in your paper. Ask yourself which sources are most likely to provide the information that will answer your research question(s). If you are writing a research paper about reality television shows, you will need to use some reality shows as a primary source, but secondary sources, such as a reviewer's critique, are also important. If you are writing about the health effects of nicotine, you will probably want to read the published results of scientific studies, but other secondary sources, such as magazine articles discussing the outcome of a recent study, may also be helpful.

Once you have thought about what kinds of sources are most likely to help you answer your research questions, you may begin your search for print and electronic resources. The challenge is to conduct your search efficiently. Writers use strategies to help them find the sources that are most relevant and reliable while steering clear of sources that will not be useful.

Scholarly Sources?

For many research assignments at post-secondary institutions, finding and reading **scholarly** (or academic) sources is a requirement of the assignment. But what is a scholarly source, and why is it important to use them?

When you search for research sources, be sure to distinguish among different types. Mass market publications, such as newspapers and popular magazines, differ from scholarly publications in their accessibility, audience, and purpose.

Newspapers and magazines are written for a broader audience than scholarly journals. Their content is usually quite accessible and easy to read. **Trade magazines** that target readers within a particular industry may presume the reader has background knowledge, but these publications are still reader friendly for a broader audience. Their purpose is to inform and, often, to entertain or persuade readers as well.

Scholarly or **academic journals** are written for a much smaller and more expert audience. The creators of these publications assume that most of their readers are already familiar with the main topic of the journal. The target audience is also highly educated. Informing is the primary purpose of a scholarly journal. While a journal article may advance an agenda or advocate a position, the content will still be presented in an objective style and formal tone (which is why you have been asked to find an academic journal article). Entertaining readers with breezy comments and splashy graphics is not a priority with this type of source.

Because of these differences, scholarly journals are more challenging to read. That does not mean you should avoid them. On the contrary, they can provide in-depth information that is unavailable elsewhere. It can be helpful to know that at the undergraduate level, most students focus on the

introduction, analysis, discussion, and conclusion sections of an article and are rarely expected to read or understand the entire thing.

There are a number of key qualities that make scholarly sources unique and preferred over non-scholarly (or what we sometimes call professional) sources:

AUTHORSHIP

Scholarly sources are **journals and books** written by and for people within the academic community, and therefore are much more likely to demonstrate the standards (example: proven research methods) and values (example: objectivity) of the academic community. These journal and books should be **peer-reviewed** by a reputable author/organization/publisher in order to be considered credible. The peer-review process consists of knowledgeable professionals and academics carefully reviewing the content of the article before publication. Peer-reviewed journals are far more likely to be reliable sources of information than what is found in popular media.

PURPOSE

By looking at scholarly sources, we can gain a better understanding of the on-going conversation between researchers. Since scholarly sources are the main avenues for publishing and sharing academic work, they often form a conversation where one researcher may try something out, report on it, then another researcher expands on those conclusions, either confirming or disproving previous findings.

Struggling to figure out if your source is scholarly or not? Try this [quiz](#) that the Sheridan Library developed to help you tell!

The Website Dilemma – Can I use this website in my research?

- [Google](#) can be a good search tool for research, if used properly. But keep in mind that Google retrieves web pages indiscriminately. As a result:
- There can be many irrelevant results, making it difficult to discover the best sources.
- It is often difficult to determine the credibility of web authors.

- Most sources are not considered scholarly.
- The best information is often hidden from Google (in the “deep web”), or requires payment.

Popular websites, like **Wikipedia** or **About.com** can be useful for personal use or as primary sources, but are not accepted as appropriate sources of information for academic research. Use them to get a quick overview of a topic or as a subject of study, but be sure to find other sources to cite in your assignments.

Learning how to evaluate a website and when it is or is not appropriate to use certain content will be an incredibly important skill for you to learn during your time here at Sheridan College.

Finding Resources

Print resources include a vast array of documents and publications. Regardless of your topic, you will consult some print resources as part of your research. (You will use electronic sources as well, but it is not wise to limit yourself to electronic sources only because some potentially useful sources may be available only in print form.) The *Library Print Resources* table below lists different types of print resources available at public and university libraries.

Library Print Resources

Resource Type	Description	Examples
Reference works	Reference works provide a summary of information about a particular topic. Almanacs, encyclopedias, atlases, medical reference books, and scientific abstracts are examples of reference works. In some cases, reference books may not be checked out of a library. Note that reference works are many steps removed from original primary sources and are often brief, so they should be used only as a starting point when you gather information.	• The World Almanac and Book of Facts 2015 • Diagnostic and Statistical Manual published by the American Psychiatric Association
Nonfiction books	Nonfiction books provide in-depth coverage of a topic. Trade books, biographies, and how-to guides are usually written for a general audience. Scholarly books and scientific studies are usually written for an audience that has specialized knowledge of a topic.	• The 30-Day Low-Carb Diet Solution • Fundamentals of Nutrition
Periodicals and news sources	These sources are published at regular intervals—daily, weekly, monthly, or quarterly. Newspapers, magazines, and academic journals are examples. Some periodicals provide articles on subjects of general interest, while others are more specialized.	• The Globe and Mail • Maclean's magazine • CMAJ, Canadian Medical Association Journal
Government publications	Federal, provincial, and local government agencies publish information on a variety of topics. Government publications include reports, legislation, court documents, public records, statistics, studies, guides, programs, and forms.	• Statistics Canada • Juristat
Business and nonprofit publications	Businesses and nonprofit organizations produce publications designed to market a product, provide background about the organization, provide information on topics connected to the organization, or promote a cause. These publications include reports, newsletters, advertisements, manuals, brochures, and other print documents.	• A company's instruction manual explaining how to use a specific software program • A news release published by UNICEF Canada

Some of these resources are also widely available in electronic format. In addition to the resources noted in the table, library holdings may include primary texts such as historical documents, letters, and diaries.

Writing at Work

Businesses, government organizations, and nonprofit organizations produce published materials that range from brief advertisements and brochures to lengthy, detailed reports. In many cases, producing these publications requires research. A corporation's annual report may include research about economic or industry trends. A charitable organization may use information from research in materials sent to potential donors.

Regardless of the industry you work in, you may be asked to assist in developing materials for publication. Often, incorporating research in these documents can make them more effective in informing or persuading readers.

Tip: If your assignment permits, strive for a balance of accessible, easy-to-read sources and more specialized, challenging sources. Relying solely on lightweight books and articles written for a general audience will drastically limit the range of useful, substantial information. On the other hand, restricting oneself to dense, scholarly works could make the process of researching extremely time consuming and frustrating.

Self-Practice Exercise

Make a list of five types of print resources you could use to find information about your topic. Include at least one primary source. Be as specific as possible. If you have a particular resource or type of resource in mind, describe it.

Self-Practice Exercise

Visit the Sheridan Library database and conduct searches on a few terms related to your topic.

Review your search results and identify six to eight additional terms you might use when you conduct your research.

Electronic Resources

With the expansion of technology and media over the past few decades, a wealth of information is available to you in electronic format. Some types of resources, such as television documentaries, may only be available electronically. Other resources—for instance, many newspapers and magazines—may be available in both print and electronic form. The following are some of the electronic sources you might consult:

- Online databases
- Popular web search engines
- Websites maintained by businesses, universities, nonprofit organizations, or government agencies
- Newspapers, magazines, and journals published on the web
- E-books
- Audiobooks
- Industry blogs
- Radio and television programs and other audio and video recordings
- Online discussion groups

The techniques you use to locate print resources can also help you find electronic resources efficiently. Libraries usually include CD-ROMs, audiobooks, and audio and video recordings among their holdings. You can locate these materials in the catalogue using a keyword search. The same Boolean operators used to refine database searches can help you filter your results in popular search engines.

Using Periodicals, Indexes, and Databases

Library catalogues can help you locate book length sources, as well as some types of non-print holdings, such as CDs, DVDs, and audiobooks. To locate shorter sources, such as magazine and journal articles, you will need to use a **periodical index** or an **online periodical database**. These tools index the articles that appear in newspapers, magazines,

and journals. Like catalogues, they provide publication information about an article and often allow users to access a summary or even the full text of the article.

Print indexes may be available in the periodicals section of your library. Increasingly, libraries use online databases that users can access through the library website. A single library may provide access to multiple periodical databases. These can range from general news databases to specialized databases. The table *Commonly Used Databases* (below) describes some indexes and databases that are frequently used.

Commonly Used Databases

Resource	Format	Contents
Academic Search (EBSCOhost)	Online	General content from magazines, journals, and books
Canadian Newsstand (ProQuest)	Online	News and current event-related content from magazines and newspapers
Business Source Complete (EBSCOhost)	Online	Business-related content from magazines and journals
Criminal Justice (ProQuest)	Online	Content from journals in criminology and law
MEDLINE (EBSCOhost) PubMed (OPEN ACCESS)	Online	Articles in medicine and health
PsycINFO (EBSCOhost)	Online	Content from journals in psychology and psychiatry
SocINDEX (EBSCOhost)	Online	General content from magazines, journals, and books

STUDENT TIP: To find resources efficiently, first identify the major concepts and terms you will use to conduct your search—that is, your **keywords**. These will help you find sources using any of the following methods:

- Using the library’s online catalogue
- Using periodicals indexes and databases
- Consulting a reference librarian

One way to identify useful keywords is to visit the Library of Congress's website at <http://id.loc.gov/authorities> (used as a point of reference throughout North America). This site allows you to search for a topic and see the related subject headings used by the Library of Congress, including broader terms, narrower terms, and related terms. Other libraries, such as Sheridan's, use these terms to classify materials, and research databases will often provide suggestions for other related words or that you might want to consider in your searches. Knowing the most-used terms will help you speed up your keyword search.

One way to refine your keyword search is to use Boolean operators. These allow you to combine keywords, find variations on a word, and otherwise expand or limit your results. Here are some of the ways you can use Boolean operators:

- Combine keywords with and or + to limit results to citations that include both keywords—for example, diet + nutrition.
- Combine keywords with **or** to find synonyms. For example, **prison or jail**. The phrase “Or is more” may help you remember that using this will show you more results.
- Combine keywords with not or – to search for the first word without the second. This can help you eliminate irrelevant results based on words that are similar to your search term. For example, searching for stress fractures not geological locates materials on fractures of *bones* but excludes materials on fractures of *stones*. Use this one cautiously because it may exclude useful sources.
- Enclose a phrase in **quotation marks** to search for an exact phrase, such as “morbid obesity,” “**use of force**,” or “**law enforcement**.”
- Use **parentheses** to direct the order of operations in a search string. For example, since Type II diabetes is also known as adult onset diabetes, you could search (Type II or adult onset or Type 2) and diabetes to limit your search results to articles on this form of the disease.
- Use a wildcard symbol such as *, #, ?, or \$ after a word to search for variations on a term. For instance, you might type gang* to search for information on gang, gangs, and gangland. The specific symbol used varies with different databases.

Using Other Information Sources: Interviews

With so many print and electronic media available, it is easy to overlook another valuable information resource: other people. Consider whether you could use a person or group as a primary source, if appropriate for your assignment. For instance, you might interview a professor who has expertise in a particular subject, a worker within a particular industry, or a representative from a political organization. Interviews can be a great way to get firsthand information.

To get the most out of an interview, you will need to plan ahead. Contact your subject early in the research process and explain your purpose for requesting an interview. Prepare detailed questions. Open-ended questions, rather than questions with simple yes or no answers, are more likely to lead to an in-depth discussion. Schedule a time to meet, and be sure to obtain your subject's permission to record the interview. Take careful notes and be ready to ask follow-up questions based on what you learn.

Writing at Work

Periodicals databases are not just for students writing research papers. They also provide a valuable service to workers in various fields. The owner of a small business might use a database such as Business Source Complete to find articles on management, finance, or trends within a particular industry. Health care professionals might consult databases such as MEDLINE to research a particular disease or medication. Regardless of what career path you plan to pursue, periodicals databases can be a useful tool for researching specific topics and identifying periodicals that will help you keep up with the latest news in your industry.

Engaging with Academic Research Sources

Selecting Sources for Your Assignment

It's important to realize that while all information is useful in some context, it will not all be useful in *your* context. The table below summarizes types of secondary sources in four tiers. All sources have their legitimate uses, but the top-tier ones are preferable for citation in academic classes. If you are a student studying other areas such as computer sciences, theatre, etc., you will find that you may use more of a cross-section of sources from different tiers in your program assignments.

Tier	Type	Content	Uses	How to find them
1	Peer-reviewed academic publications	Rigorous research and analysis	Provide strong evidence for claims and references to other high-quality sources	Google Scholar, library catalogs, and academic article databases
2	Reports, articles, and books from credible non-academic sources	Well researched and even-handed descriptions of an event or state of the world	Initial research on events or trends not yet analyzed in the academic literature; may reference important Tier 1 sources	Websites of relevant agencies, Google searches using (site: *.gov or site: *.org), academic article databases
3	Short pieces from newspapers or credible websites	Simple reporting of events, research findings, or policy changes	Often point to useful Tier 2 or Tier 1 sources, may provide a factoid or two not found anywhere else	Strategic Google searches or article databases including newspapers and magazines
4	Agenda-driven or uncertain pieces	Mostly opinion, varying in thoughtfulness and credibility	May represent a particular position within a debate; more often provide keywords and clues about higher quality sources	Non-specific Google searches

Tier 1: Peer-reviewed academic publications

These are sources from the mainstream academic literature: books and scholarly articles. Academic books generally fall into three categories: (1) textbooks written with students in mind, (2) monographs which give an extended report on a large research project, and (3) edited volumes in which each chapter is authored by different people. Scholarly articles appear in academic journals, which are published multiple times a year in order to share the latest research findings with scholars in the field. They're usually sponsored by an academic society, institution, or organization.

Tier 2: Reports, articles and books from credible non-academic sources

Some events and trends are too recent to appear in Tier 1 sources. Also, Tier 1 sources tend to be highly specific, and sometimes you need a more general perspective on a topic. Thus, Tier 2 sources can provide quality information that is more accessible to non-academics. There are three main categories. First, official reports from government agencies or major international institutions like the [World Bank](#) or the [United Nations](#); these institutions generally have research departments staffed with qualified experts who seek to provide rigorous, even-handed information to decision-makers. Second, feature articles from major newspapers and magazines like the [New York Times](#), [Wall Street Journal](#), [London Times](#), or [The Economist](#) are based on original reporting by experienced journalists (not press releases) and are typically 1500+ words in length. Third, there are some great books from non-academic presses that cite their sources; they're often written by journalists. All three of these sources are generally well researched descriptions of an event or state of the world, undertaken by credentialed experts who generally seek to be even-handed. It is still up to you to judge their credibility. Your instructors and campus librarians can advise you on which sources in this category have the most credibility.

Tier 3: Short pieces from periodicals or credible websites

A step below the well-developed reports and feature articles that make up Tier 2 are the short tidbits that one finds in newspapers and magazines or credible websites. How short is a short news article? Usually, they're just a couple paragraphs or less, and they're often reporting on just one thing: an event, an interesting research finding, or a policy change. They don't take extensive research and analysis to write, and many just summarize a press release written and distributed by an organization or business. They may describe things like corporate mergers, newly discovered diet-health links, or important school-funding legislation. You may want to cite Tier 3 sources in your paper if they provide an important factoid or two that isn't provided by a higher-tier piece, but if the Tier 3 article describes a particular study or academic expert, your best bet is to find the journal article or book it is reporting on and use that Tier 1 source instead. If the article mentions which journal the study was published in, you can go right to that journal through your library website. Sometimes you can find the original journal article by putting the scholar's name and some keywords into Google Scholar.

What counts as a credible website in this tier? You may need some guidance from instructors or librarians, but you can learn a lot by examining the person or organization providing the information (look for an “About” link). For example, if the organization is clearly agenda-driven or not up-front about its aims and/or funding sources, then it definitely isn’t something you want to cite as a neutral authority. Also look for signs of expertise. A tidbit about a medical research finding written by someone with a science background carries more weight than the same topic written by a policy analyst. These sources are sometimes uncertain, which is all the more reason to follow the trail to a Tier 1 or Tier 2 source whenever possible.

Personally, research papers are my thing! They give me a chance to further explore a topic that I usually am genuinely interested in, and it gives me the opportunity to write down everything I know. Sources are easy to find; they’re everywhere. Unfortunately, the useful ones you have to put in a little more effort to find. As much as I love Wikipedia, if I’m going to take the time to write a paper, I want it to be taken seriously. There are so many resources out there to help students find scholarly information. The better the source, the more supported your paper will be. But it doesn’t matter how well supported or amazing your paper is if you don’t cite your sources! A citing mistake could definitely get you a big fat zero on the paper you worked so hard on, and maybe even kicked out of school. Utilize resources like www.easybib.com for a quick works cited, and Purdue’s OWL (english.purdue.edu/owl) for a complete and easy explanation on APA and MLA citing formats.

-Aly Button

Tier 4: Agenda-driven or pieces from unknown sources

This tier is essentially everything else, including Wikipedia. Wikipedia is a conundrum. There are a lot of excellent articles on there, and I, like many other professors, embrace the open-access values that embody things like Wikipedia and this very textbook. It’s not that Wikipedia is crap; it’s just that there are much more solid alternatives. These types of sources—especially Wikipedia—can be hugely helpful in identifying interesting topics, positions within a debate, keywords to search on, and, sometimes, higher-tier sources on the topic. They often play a critically important role in the early part of the research process, but they generally aren’t (and shouldn’t be) cited in the final paper. Throwing some keywords into [Google](https://www.google.com) and seeing what you get is a fine way to get started, but don’t stop there. Start a list of the people, organizations, sources, and keywords that seem most relevant to your topic. For example, suppose you’ve been assigned a research paper about the impact of linen production and trade on the ancient world. A quick Google search reveals that (1) linen comes from the flax plant, (2) the scientific name for flax is *Linum usitatissimum*, (3) Egypt dominated linen production at the height of its empire, and (4) Alex J. Warden published a book about ancient linen trade in 1867. Similarly, you found some useful search terms to try instead of “ancient world” (antiquity, Egyptian empire, ancient Egypt, ancient Mediterranean) and some generalizations for linen (fabric, textiles, or weaving). Now you’ve got a lot to work with as you tap into the library catalog and academic article databases.

Origins and Anatomy of a Journal Article

Most of the Tier 1 sources available are academic articles, also called scholarly articles, scholarly papers, journal articles, academic papers, or peer-reviewed articles. They all mean the same thing: a paper published in an academic periodical after being scrutinized anonymously and judged to be sound by other experts in the subfield. Their origin explains both their basic structure and the high esteem they have in the eyes of your professors.

Many journals are sponsored by academic associations. Most of your professors belong to at least one big, general one (such as the [Modern Language Association](#), the [American Psychological Association](#), the [National Association for Sport and Physical Education](#), or the [American Physical Society](#)) and one or more smaller ones organized around particular areas of interest and expertise (such as the [Association for the Study of Food and Society](#), the [International Association for Statistical Computing](#), or the [Slavic and East European Folklore Association](#)). There are also generalist organizations organized by region of the country or state, such as the [Eastern Sociological Society](#) or the [Southern Management Association](#). Each of these associations exists to promote the exchange of research findings and collaboration in their disciplines. Towards this end, they organize conferences, sponsor working groups, and publish one or more academic journals. These journals are meant to both publicize and archive the most interesting and important findings of the field.

Academic papers are essentially reports or essays that scholars write to their peers—present and future—about what they’ve done in their research, what they’ve found, and why they think it’s important. Thus, in a lot of fields they often have a structure reminiscent of the lab reports you’ve written for science classes:

1. *Abstract*: A one-paragraph summary of the article: its purpose, methods, findings, and significance.
2. *Introduction*: An overview of the key question or problem that the paper addresses, why it is important, and the key conclusion(s) (i.e., thesis or theses) of the paper.
3. *Literature review*: A synthesis of all the relevant prior research (the so-called “academic literature” on the subject) that explains why the paper makes an original and important contribution to the body of knowledge.
4. *Data and methods*: An explanation of what data or information the author(s) used and what they did with it.
5. *Results*: A full explanation of the key findings of the study.
6. *Conclusion/discussion*: Puts the key findings or insights from the paper into their broader context; explains why they matter.

But beware! Not all papers are so “sciencey.” For example, a historical or literary analysis doesn’t necessarily have a “data and methods” section; however, they do explain and justify the research question, describe how the authors’ own points relate to those made in other relevant articles and books, develop the key insights yielded by the analysis, and conclude by explaining their significance. Some academic papers are review articles, in which the “data” are published papers and the “findings” are key insights, enduring lines of debate, and/or remaining unanswered questions. Here are some strategies to research more efficiently:

1. *Find them quickly*. Instead of paging through mountains of dubious web content, familiarize yourself with relevant scholarly article databases in order to quickly find the highest quality sources.
2. *Use the abstracts*. Abstracts tell you immediately whether or not the article you’re holding is relevant or useful to the paper you’re assigned to write. You shouldn’t ever have the experience of reading the whole paper just to discover it’s not useful.
3. *Read strategically*. Knowing the anatomy of a scholarly article tells you what you should be reading for in each section. For example, you don’t necessarily need to understand every nuance of the literature review. You can just focus on why the authors claim that their own study is distinct from the ones that came before.
4. *Don’t sweat the technical stuff*. Not every social scientist understands the intricacies of log-linear modeling of quantitative survey data; however, the reviewers definitely do, and they found the analysis to be well constructed. Thus, you can accept the findings as legitimate and just focus on the passages that explain the findings and their

significance in plainer language.

5. *Use one article to find others.* If you have one really good article that's a few years old, you can use article databases to find newer articles that cited it in their own literature reviews. That immediately tells you which ones are on the same topic and offer newer findings. On the other hand, if your first source is very recent, the literature review section will describe the other papers in the same line of research. You can look them up directly.

Research papers, amongst others, are the most common papers a college student will ever write, and as difficult as it may sound, it is not impossible to complete. Research papers are my favorite kind of papers because of sourcing, paraphrasing, and quoting. Naturally as you would in other papers, your own paper should come from yourself, but when you are proving a point about a specific area of your topic, it is always ok to have a credible source explain further. In college, sources are very important for most, if not all papers you will have, and citing those sources is important as well. After you are able to familiarize yourself with citations, it will come natural like it has for many students.

-Timothée Pizarro

Students sometimes grumble when they're ordered to use scholarly articles in their research. It seems a lot easier to just Google some terms and find stuff that way. However, academic articles are often the most reliable resources out there. They are vetted by experts and structured specifically to help readers zero in on the most important parts of a given topic.

Using Evidence

Both academic and professional sources will engage with various types of evidence – that is, data that has been collected in order to support or refute a point in an academic discussion. We rely on evidence all the time in day to day life. When people make seemingly ridiculous claims or pose a difficult question, someone might ask that they “Google that!” Or if you're debating a topic with someone, they may ask you how you knew something or where you found certain information. We also engage in this process quite naturally. When we share knowledge or opinions with other people, often we provide context: “I was on Reddit yesterday and I saw...” It can be helpful for students to consider the relationship between argument and presenting evidence like a court case: you are offering an interpretation of events and using data to support your claims.

The only real difference in the context of academic writing is that we formalize our use of evidence and where it came from. This process is called **citation and referencing**. Here are some of the different **types of evidence** that you may encounter as you research:

- **Facts** are statements that can be definitely proven using objective data. The statement that is a fact is absolutely valid. In other words, the statement can be pronounced as true or false based upon the fact that the same results can be recreated over and over again consistently. For example, $2 + 2 = 4$. This expression identifies a true

statement, or a fact, because it can be proved with objective data.

- **Opinions** are personal views, or judgments. An opinion is what an individual believes about a particular subject. However, an opinion in argumentation must have legitimate backing; adequate evidence and credibility should support the opinion. Consider the credibility of expert opinions, as experts in a given field have the knowledge and credentials to make their opinion meaningful to a larger audience. For example, you seek the opinion of your dentist when it comes to the health of your gums, and you seek the opinion of your mechanic when it comes to the maintenance of your car. Both have knowledge and credentials in those respective fields, which is why their opinions matter to you. But the authority of your dentist may be greatly diminished should he or she offer an opinion about your car, and vice versa. In your writing, you want to strike a balance between credible facts and authoritative opinions. Relying on one or the other will likely lose more of your audience than it gains.
- **Statistics** are the results of surveys or other means of data collection. A statistic is typically expressed as a percentage (“25% of students...” OR “1 in 4 students...”) or a ratio (“the class had a gender ration of 1:4 women to men”). It is important to note that *statistics* are NOT *facts*. Because someone else could run a study and find different results, a statistic is distinct from a fact.
- **Testimony (Expert, Eye-Witness)** is often used in subjective arguments where first-hand or personal experience is an important factor. **Expert** testimony is when people who are proficient in a related field of study are called upon to speak to certain facts or theories. **Eye-witness** testimony is when the details of a particular event are important and need to be recounted.
- **Legal** evidence is typically primary evidence – it’s the law and regulations that outline the rules and consequences in a given society. For example, you might find the Canadian [Criminal Code](#) helpful in supporting an argument that has a legal component.
- **Visual Evidence**

There are two main types of visual elements: quantitative visuals and qualitative visuals.

Quantitative visuals present data graphically. They allow the audience to see statistics spatially. The purpose of using quantitative visuals is to make logical appeals to the audience. For example, sometimes it is easier to understand the disparity in certain statistics if it is displayed graphically. Bar graphs, pie charts, Venn diagrams, histograms, and line graphs are all ways of presenting quantitative data in spatial dimensions and allow you to present a large amount of information in a way that is quick and easy for the reader to understand. The data being presented has usually been collected from some sort of (in)formal study (such as a survey) and has been arranged in visual format to help demonstrate patterns or trends to the reader.

Qualitative visuals present images that appeal to the audience’s emotions. Photographs and pictorial images are examples of qualitative visuals. Such images often try to convey a story, and seeing an actual example can carry more power than hearing or reading about the example. For example, one image of a child suffering from malnutrition will likely have more of an emotional impact than pages dedicated to describing that same condition in writing.

Adding visual elements to a persuasive argument can often strengthen its persuasive effect. However, remember you want to use them to make a bigger impact for your reader, so you need to make sure they are:

- **Relevant and essential.** They should help your reader visualize your point.
- **Easy to follow.** The reader should not have to work too hard to understand.
- **Appropriate to audience, tone, and purpose.** Always keep the audience in mind.
- **Appropriately cited and referenced.** If you borrow from a source, be sure to include proper citations.

- **NOT disrespectful.** You want your writing to be seen as fair and non-biased.
- **NOT used too often.** They will become more of a distraction than a focal point if they are used too often
- **Cited.** Just like textual evidence, you are required to cite visual evidence using in-text citations (if applicable) and a reference page. There will be very specific formatting requirements as well, based upon the referencing style you are using (MLA, APA, Chicago, etc), so be sure to consult a handbook for the rules and expectations.

Writing at Work

When making a business presentation, you typically have limited time to get your idea across. Providing visual elements for your audience can be an effective timesaving tool. Quantitative visuals in business presentations serve the same purpose as they do in persuasive writing. They should make logical appeals by showing numerical data in a spatial design. Quantitative visuals should be pictures that might appeal to your audience's emotions or perceptions. You will find that many of the rhetorical devices used in writing are the same ones used in the workplace.

How much evidence?

You need enough evidence to support your claims and arguments, but you want to be certain that evidence is not speaking for you or drowning out your own voice in your assignment. This mistake is a common one amongst undergraduate students who feel like they need to “prove everything” that they say in an assignment. A good way to think about the threshold is that no more than 30% (roughly) of an essay or assignment should be other people's words or ideas, unless your professor indicates otherwise.

Try to mix up how you present your evidence to your audience: use a combination of paraphrases and direct quotations so that the paper doesn't read as though it has been scripted.

How can I avoid plagiarism if I have to use research to support my claims? Doesn't that mean that my points have already been made?

You may find yourself frustrated with the demands of your professors to “think for yourself” or “come up with your own thoughts.” After all, if you were an expert in the topic, you'd hardly be in school getting an education. It's important to understand that at this level, your professors don't necessarily equate “new” with “original”; in other words, while you may not have new *ideas*, you can certainly come up with original ways of *presenting* your thoughts and connecting them to research that you have read. In fact, the odds

are unlikely that you will come up with something “new” at this point in your academic journey – you simply haven’t spent enough time in your field of study yet.

So, when you are writing more traditional assignments and using evidence, the following questions might help:

1. What do I think about what this source is saying? Do I agree or disagree? Do I accept part of what is being said? Remember: even if you disagree with a source, you can still use it in your assignment and explain what the other author missed.
2. How does this source connect with other things that I’ve read?
3. Does the source provide me with any useful definitions or ideas upon which I can build my own discussion?

When to cite evidence?

Evidence is really about helping your reader to make sense of what has already been said or discussed about your topic so that they don’t have to go do a bunch of research just to get through one paragraph of your essay. When you make a claim or assertion, you don’t want your reader needing to go look things up to figure out if it’s true. Therefore, the point of evidence is not to “back up” common knowledge (such as the fact that the sun rises in the East, or that the Seven Years War was seven years long) – it’s to demonstrate the validity of information that one cannot expect others to know without researching it.

Another way to consider whether or not you need to cite something is to ask yourself: *is this knowledge proprietary?* Does someone “own” it? For example, no one “owns” the claim that the world is round; however, a quotation or a statistic has been said or determined by *someone* – we can attribute it to an individual, group, or organization (hence the other, less common name for “citation,” which is “attribution”).

Here is a brief list of things that *do* need to be cited:

- Statistics & data
- Quotations
- Theories and claims of other writers
- Visuals
- Content created by someone online (blogs, wikis, etc)
- Books, articles, and other sources

Direct quotations are when you are using the author’s exact words as they appear on the page in your source – you don’t change or move any words around, and you use quotation marks (“ ”) to indicate that you are quoting the source. **Paraphrases** or summary is when you take the author’s idea or concept and *rewrite it using your own words*. Here, you cite the idea that the source has presented. Paraphrases are useful when you’re talking about an entire article or work, or if you are speaking about information or concepts in a general sense where the precise details in the source are not as necessary or as relevant to your discussion.

When you go to insert evidence into your writing, it is important to use a **signal phrase** – that is, a phrase or clause that introduces a quotation or paraphrase. The signal phrase is particularly important when it comes to paraphrasing because it helps the reader understand where your ideas stop and the citation begins. In other words, the signal phrase and the in-text citation “sandwich” the evidence – both

direct quotations and paraphrases – to help the reader determine what is evidence and what is your own work.

Below, you will see some examples of signal phrases:

- As _____ once said:
- In their (2001) study, Drodger and Keller noted:
- In her discussion on _____, Chopra states:
- According to research done by _____,

Here is an example of how signal phrases may be used in body paragraphs. The first example is a direct quotation and the second is a paraphrase. Note how the signal phrase and the citation create a clear sense of where the evidence is located in the paragraph:

The English Civil War took place from 1640-1660 and had a tremendous impact on that country's population. In 1660, when Charles II came back to claim the throne of England, many of the nation's writers and dramatists were using literature as a means of processing the losses and outcomes of the Civil War. **Thomas P. Anderson (2016) discusses** how dramatists used plots of revenge to help audiences process the death of loved ones during the war: "registering a generation's inability to move beyond the loss of the community of the dead, the revenge stage offers its vision of early modern communities – peopled with body parts, skeletons, [...] corpses, and disembodied voices – that try to compensate for, even as they repeat, the traumatic loss of the place of the dead" (126-127). Anderson contends that the revenge drama became a cathartic space for audiences as they attempted to process the violence and the trauma that impacted England during the war. **Anderson argues further** that, in these revenge plays, the presence of blood serves as a relic that was being exchanged between the living and the dead; it was a physical reminder of death for the audience because it left a visible residue of a life that had ended (146). For those audience members who were struggling to work through the losses of the civil war, drama was able to demonstrate different methods for people to cope and process the pain, but it also complicates the ability of people to move on in life because that same painful history had been immortalized in popular dramatic literature.

As you can see, using signal phrases helps to distinguish your ideas and analysis from the sources you are quoting; thus, signal phrases are an excellent way to help students avoid inadvertent plagiarism or an over-dependence on secondary sources. You can find more examples of signal phrases in *They Say, I Say: Moves that Matter in Academic Writing* (see the **Additional Resources** section at the back of this book).

Discover Sheridan's Library Services¹

Consulting a Reference Librarian

Sifting through library stacks and database search results to find the information you need can be like trying to find a needle in a haystack. If you are not sure how you should begin your search, or if it is yielding too many or too few results, you are not alone. Many students find this process challenging, although it does get easier with experience. One way to learn better search strategies is to consult a reference librarian.

Reference librarians are intimately familiar with the systems libraries use to organize and classify information. They can help you locate a particular book in the library stacks, steer you toward useful reference works, and provide tips

on how to use databases and other electronic research tools. Take the time to see what resources you can find on your own, but if you encounter difficulties, ask for help. Many college and university librarians hold virtual office hours and are available for online chatting.

What services does the Sheridan Library offer?

Sheridan's Library collects academic material related to all programs and courses offered at Sheridan. Along with the traditional library materials in print (books, journals, etc), they increasingly collect online material so that you can easily access our content at any time from anywhere!

For a more comprehensive overview of the Sheridan Library, check out their [First Year Quick Start Guide](#).

Databases & Streaming Media

We have over 200 databases on a wide range of subjects and disciplines. Use the [A-Z Database List](#) to access databases and streaming media sites, which includes content from journal articles, newspapers, images, videos, tutorials, and more.

Ebooks

We currently have more ebooks than books on the shelves! We get ebooks from more than one company. Some can be downloaded, but most are available without downloading. All you need is your Sheridan Credentials to access them! Find ebooks through [Summon](#).

Textbooks & Course Reserves

The titles of the textbooks and course readings for your courses can be found in the [course outline](#) for each of your courses.

Textbooks are available for 3hr loan periods at each campus library. Our textbooks are intended to be used for quick reference only. We recommend that students purchase their own copies. Search for your textbook titles in [Summon](#).

Course reserves are typically non-textbook items that a professor has recommended for reading. Loan periods are generally 2hr loans, but may vary. Course reserves are kept behind the service desk at each campus library. **Ask staff at the library service desk.**

English Language Learning (ELL) Resources

We have many resources available for all levels of ESL students to improve reading, writing, listening and speaking skills. See our [English Language Learning Guide](#) for more details.

Games & Equipment

You can now borrow board games, video games and PlayStation game consoles from the library! Board games are available at Davis campus library. Video games and PlayStation consoles are available at Trafalgar campus library. Visit us in person to check them out, and see the Borrowing Policy below for more details.

Study Spaces

All Sheridan campus libraries and learning commons provide a range of environments for different needs.

- Quiet study areas
- Group study areas where you can collaborate and chat
- Private group study rooms

Book a [Group Study Room](#) online.

Tutoring Services

At the Tutoring Centre, Learning Assistants (LAs) offer tutoring in specific subject areas (listed below) at no additional cost to you as a Sheridan student. As senior co-op students recruited from Sheridan, University of Waterloo, Ryerson, and University of Guelph, the LAs in the Tutoring Centre are knowledgeable and well qualified to support you in your studies.

How it Works:

Tutoring sessions with Learning Assistants (LAs) are offered in ½ hour and 1 hour appointments, or shorter drop-in sessions. The subjects covered by LAs are listed below.

Book up to 2 hours per week, per subject.

- [Book an Appointment](#) – first-time users must register using a Sheridan email address
- [Drop-in Hours](#) – Varies from term to term
- Not able to come visit us during our open hours? Email us with your questions and/or comments at tutoring@sheridancollege.ca

Subjects:

- **Architecture** – Covers the use of architecture-related software (e.g., AutoCAD, Sketchup), as well as technical math, drafting, and other related topics. Plus, your LA can provide explanations of OBC standards and help you better understand course material.
- **Chemistry** – Covers fundamental issues related to Chemistry, Organic and Biochemistry from a health perspective (Pharmacy, Nursing, Nutrition and Medicine).
- **Citation & References** – Covers how to build and correct your citations and references for your writing assignments (APA, MLA and other styles). Bring your references, sources, and citation questions! By appointment only.
- **Computer Programming** – Covers object-oriented programming (Java 1 and Java 2) and other computer

programming-related questions.

- **English/Writing** – Covers writing practice, presentation skills, basic computing, study and test-taking skills, citing sources, and pronunciation. In addition, LAs can review a portion of your assignment for structure and grammar and offer constructive feedback on content and style. NOTE: Your LA cannot proofread an entire assignment for you, but they can help you improve your proof-reading skills.
- **Math & Business Math** – Covers general Math, most Business Math topics (e.g., Accounting, Finance, Statistics, etc.), as well as many technical Math and related topics. Your LA can provide explanations of math concepts, and patiently help you problem solve your way to finding solutions and understanding your subject better.

Group Sessions:

- **English Conversation Circles** – Practice your English speaking skills in small groups. Join Learning Assistants for these informal sessions planned by ESL faculty and hosted by English/Writing LAs. See [Hours & Locations](#) for the current schedule.
- **Varsity Athletics Study Hall** – During scheduled times, Varsity Athletes take over the Tutoring Centre to do independent studies. One English and one math tutor are always present during these hours in case they need any help. See [Hours & Locations](#) for the current schedule.

How can the library help with my research?

The library carries a wide variety of high-quality, credible resources covering the many topics relevant to the programs being taught at Sheridan. Our resources come in digital and print format. They may be either scholarly or non-scholarly publications.

Digital/Online Collections

In today's technology and computer driven world, most resources collected by the library are now in digital form. Digital, or online collections are held in what we call **databases**.

Much like Netflix, databases are unique sites on the Internet, holding large collections of articles, or books, or videos, etc. Databases are carefully selected by librarians for their relevance to Sheridan programs. The library subscribes to a wide variety of databases. Databases often focus on particular types of publications – such as journal articles, books, business reports, etc. Some databases focus on specific subject areas (such as engineering, health, or business).

Types of Publications

The types of publications you choose are important – whether online or in print, scholarly or non-scholarly, traditional or non-traditional. Different publications suit different purposes and provide different kinds of information. Be sure to explore a variety of resources.

Books

Great for full discussions of topics or to orient yourself to a subject area. In some cases, you may find even just one chapter useful.

Periodicals & News Sources

Publications that are published on a regular basis – daily, weekly, bi-weekly, monthly, bi-monthly, quarterly, seasonally, or yearly. Each issue of the publication has multiple articles, each written by a different author. Excellent for getting news, opinions, personal and professional experiences, and more. Credibility and coverage vary by publication.

Multi-Media Resources

A variety of resources that can enhance your understanding of a topic, or add visual interest to a presentation.

Where do I start my Search?

Use [Summon](#) to find content from the many different databases and collections that we subscribe to, as well as items on library shelves. A great place to start your search!

Once you become familiar with library resources, you'll quickly get to know which databases are best for your specific information need. We list all of our databases and sites through the [Databases A-Z](#) list.

View library-created [Research Guides](#) to find all types of resources specific to your research topics.

Key Terms and Concepts

- Reliability (of sources)
- Credibility (of sources)
- Reputability (of sources)
 - Bias

- Paradigm
- Hidden Agenda
- Relevancy (of sources)
- Currency (of sources)
 - Timeliness
- CRAAP Test
- Primary Source
- Secondary Source
- Scholarly (Academic) Source
 - Peer-Review
- Evidence
 - Facts
 - Opinions
 - Statistics
 - Testimony
 - Legal
 - Visual
- Citation and Referencing
- Plagiarism
- Direct Quotation
- Paraphrase
- Signal Phrase
- Sheridan Library Services

¹ Content adapted from the Sheridan College Library: <https://www.sheridancollege.ca/life-at-sheridan/student-services/library-services.aspx>

4. Media Literacy and Communicating in Public Contexts

Chapter 4 Content Summary:

- Media and Digital Literacy
- Analyzing (Visual) Media
- Giving Effective Presentations

Writing for Public Purposes

Obviously, writing won't always be a private thing that you do for yourself. You may end up writing with an intent to publish your work, producing training materials for a company, or designing advertisements to sell products. There is almost a guarantee that you will need to write something for a wider audience at some point in your life. When our writing moves beyond a simple readership and out into the world of mass media, the composition and rhetorical strategies must shift as well.

What does it mean to be “media literate”?

The concept of media continues to evolve as new technology and means of production emerge. **Media** (plural for **medium**) are methods or means of mass communication. Varying forms of media include television, radio, newspapers, magazines, academic journals, websites, and videos, but can also include popular culture artifacts or texts, such as toys, video games, and fashion. In short, to be **media literate** is to be able to “critically understand the nature, techniques and impacts of media messages and productions” (Media Smarts).

Below are some points and questions, taken from the Canadian website [Media Smarts](#), that we might ask ourselves in order to understand different types of media critically:

1. Media are constructions

Media products are created by individuals who make conscious and unconscious choices about what to include, what to leave out and how to present what is included. These decisions are based on the creators' own point of view, which will have been shaped by their opinions, assumptions and biases – as well as media they have been exposed to. As a result of this, media products are never entirely accurate reflections of the real world – even the most objective documentary filmmaker has to decide what footage to use and what to cut, as well as where to put the camera – but we instinctively view many media products as direct representations of what is real.

Ask yourself:

- Who created this media product?
- What is its purpose?
- What assumptions or beliefs do its creators have that are reflected in the content?

2. Audiences negotiate meaning

The meaning of any media product is not created solely by its producers but is, instead, a collaboration between them and the audience – which means that different audiences can take away different meanings from the same product. Media literacy encourages us to understand how individual factors, such as age, gender, race and social status affect our interpretations of media.

Ask yourself:

- How might different people see this media product differently?
- How does this make you feel, based on how similar or different you are from the people portrayed in the media product?

3. Media have commercial implications

Most media production is a business and must, therefore, make a profit. In addition, media industries belong to a powerful network of corporations that exert influence on content and distribution. Questions of ownership and control are central – a relatively small number of individuals control what we watch, read and hear in the media. Even in cases where media content is not made for profit – such as YouTube videos and Facebook posts – the ways in which content is distributed are nearly always run with profit in mind.

Ask yourself:

- What is the commercial purpose of this media product (in other words, how will it help someone make money)?
- How does this influence the content and how it's communicated?
- If no commercial purpose can be found, what other purposes might the media product have (for instance, to get attention for its creator or to convince audiences of a particular point of view)?
- How do those purposes influence the content and how it's communicated?

4. Media have social and political implications

Media convey ideological messages about values, power and authority. In media literacy, what or who is absent may be more important than what or who is included. These messages may be the result of conscious decisions, but more often they are the result of unconscious biases and unquestioned assumptions – and they can have a significant influence on what we think and believe.

As a result, media have great influence on politics and on forming social change. TV news coverage and advertising can greatly influence the election of a national leader on the basis of image; representations of world issues, both in journalism and fiction, can affect how much attention they receive; and society's views towards different groups can be directly influenced by how – and how often – they appear in media.

Ask yourself:

- Who and what is shown in a positive light? In a negative light?
- Why might these people and things be shown this way?
- Who and what is not shown at all?
- What conclusions might audiences draw based on these facts?

5. Each medium has a unique aesthetic form

The content of media depends in part on the nature of the medium. This includes the technical, commercial and

storytelling demands of each medium: for instance, the interactive nature of video games leads to different forms of storytelling – and different demands on media creators – that are found in film and TV.

Ask yourself:

- What techniques does the media product use to get your attention and to communicate its message?
- In what ways are the images in the media product manipulated through various techniques (for example: lighting, makeup, camera angle, photo manipulation)?
- What are the expectations of the *genre* (for example: print advertising, TV drama, music video) towards its subject?

Social Media Safety: Safeguarding Yourself and Your Professional Reputation

Using digital media – particularly social media – comes with more complicated risks than more traditional forms of mass media. Navigating the online world involves developing **digital literacy**, which includes understanding a wide variety of ethical, social and reflective practices that are embedded in work, learning, leisure and daily life online.

Many of you who are reading this book are **digital natives** (those who grew up with technology, including computers and the internet), while others will be **digital immigrants** (those who are coming to technology later in life). Whether you are a digital native or digital immigrant, [Media Smarts](#) notes that there are a few things worth knowing and remembering when you engage with digital media:

1. Digital media are networked.

Unlike traditional media, there are no one-way connections in digital media. In traditional media, content only flowed one way: producers created it, then sold or licensed it to distributors who then brought it to you. In digital media, by contrast, you're no longer the final link in a distribution chain but a node in the middle of an infinite network. You can share content with other people as easily as a producer or distributor shares it with you. Collaboration and dialogue are the norm, rather than solitary creation and broadcasting.

These links are always at least two-way, even if you're not aware of the ways you're sending data. This means that everyone and everything is linked to everything else. As a result, the barriers to participation are much lower than in traditional media and anyone can publish content and find an audience. This means that users can interact with peers and celebrities at the same time, and also has important implications when we need to authenticate information or recognize a source's bias and point of view. The networked nature of digital media also makes it possible for formal and informal communities to develop online, whose norms and values are created by their members.

2. Digital media are persistent, searchable and shareable.

Digital content is permanent: everything that is transmitted is stored somewhere and can be searched for and indexed. When considered together with the concept that digital media are networked, this means that most of this content can also be copied, shared or spread at a trivial cost. Even things that are apparently temporary (like Snapchat photos) can be copied, and are almost always stored on the platform's servers.

Because it's persistent, digital content is mostly consumed asynchronously: we typically react or reply to something at a time other than when it's posted, and reactions to our reaction will also come at a later, usually unpredictable time. This can make digital media hard to turn off, since a reaction – or a chance for us to respond to something – may come at any time.

3. Digital media have unknown and unexpected audiences.

Because digital media are networked and digital content is shareable, what you share online may be seen by people you didn't intend or expect to see it. Your ability to control who sees what is limited: both content creators and traditional gatekeepers and distributors have much less power to control what happens to it once it's posted. This can make it difficult to manage audiences, and there is always a risk of context collapse when what was

intended for one audience is seen by another. As well, you may be sharing content that you're not aware of with audiences you don't know about, such as cookies and other tracking tools that record information about who you are and what you do when you visit a website.

4. Digital media experiences are real, but don't always feel real.

Being networked means that all digital media are, to at least a certain extent, interactive: we are never just passive viewers but always a part of what's happening. Because it's interactive we often respond to things online as though we are really there, but most of the cues that tell us how we and others feel are absent. One result of this can be "empathy traps," features of networked interaction – such as a feeling of being anonymous, or the absence of cues such as tone of voice or facial expressions in the people we interact with – that prevent us from feeling empathy when we normally would, and these traps can make us forget that what we do online can have real consequences. For the same reasons, it can be very difficult to determine someone's actual meaning and motivation when interacting with them online.

Partly because of this, and also because of the lack of physical presence online (we may not even entirely feel we're "in" our bodies, as we're usually sitting and immobile when using digital media), it's easy to forget that laws, morals and rights still apply online – this is how we get social media "trolls" and "keyboard warriors". The norms and values of the online communities we're part of can also affect our own personal norms and values, as the values of our offline communities do.

Taken together with the lowered barriers to publication discussed above, this can also mean that the people and images we interact with online affect us as much or more than images in traditional media because they are (or seem to be) our peers. The images of ourselves we create online have an extra impact on us because they embody who we imagine (or wish) ourselves to be.

5. How we respond and behave when using digital media is influenced by the architecture of the platforms, which reflects the biases and assumptions of their creators.

One of the most fundamental insights of media literacy is that the form of a medium influences how we "read" or experience a text. While this remains true in digital media, the network effect means that the architecture of a platform – everything from the user interface we interact with to the algorithms that determine how it delivers content to us – affects not just the meaning and message of digital media but also our own behaviour when using them. On the most fundamental level, for example, the networked nature of digital media creates a centripetal effect, as hyperlinks encourage us to move to other texts and platforms.

As with traditional media, these influences are not natural or neutral: they reflect the beliefs, unconscious biases and unquestioned assumptions of their creators. Sometimes these values will be consciously applied: if a platform's designers consider freedom of speech their top priority, then protections from hate speech and harassment will be an afterthought at best – which will influence who feels free to speak and what kinds of conversations happen. But unconscious attitudes can be at play, too, such as an "engineering mindset" that sees no problem with showing different job listings for Black and White users, or with delivering an ever-narrower feed of news that you're sure to agree with if that's the most efficient and effective way to advertise to you. As is almost always the case, commercial considerations are also key: a platform that makes money from user engagement will naturally encourage interactions that produce the most intense engagement, no matter the content or tenor of those interactions.

There is often an interplay between the influence of platforms and users' own needs, as can occur in traditional media as well. Teens may choose to post casual photos on Snapchat and more formal ones on Instagram, for instance, based on how they see the two platforms serving their purposes differently, but they are also being influenced by the structure of those platforms: Snapchat, where photos are temporary by default, creates an expectation of being casual and "fun," while Instagram's persistent feed promotes the careful maintenance of a public-facing profile.

Analyzing Visual Media

Don't have an art background? Don't worry. You probably know a lot more about this subject than you realize. Everyday, people are surrounded by images and you may be familiar with some of the tricks that artists use to create a reaction in the reader, such as making the most important parts of an image larger and light, and the less important ones in the background or fading darker.

Before we get into *how* to analyze visual media, let's start with a quick definition of the verb **analyze**: “*examine methodically and in detail the constitution or structure of (something, especially information), typically for purposes of explanation and interpretation*” (Google). What this verb tells us is that our job is to break down and examine the various parts that make up the subject (font, colour, texture, artistic medium, etc) and think about how those elements work together to create meaning for the audience.

With that goal in mind, most visual analysis will begin with a clear and vivid description of the image along with an analysis of the visual composition of the picture in order to explain how the artist put the image together to create meaning. Although visual analysis often focuses a lot on the details of describing the image, don't fall into the trap of simply describing the work or talking about what you see – remember: your goal is to **analyze, not just describe**. You will need a thesis which presents your interpretation or understanding of the image. There are several ways to do this and your assignment may tell you in which direction to go. To analyze for meaning, we ask ourselves how certain **compositional techniques** (layout and content choices) are being used to evoke specific thoughts, feelings, or opinions in the viewer. The list below will help you to describe the visual elements of the image and analyze how each element helps to create meaning:

- Think about the meaning of the image for the artist in the context of their time
- Consider the meaning of the image in the context of you and your time
- Think about the changes in meaning of an image over the course of time – how have social values and norms shifted how we understand a text (is it racist, misogynistic, etc)
- Consider the audience's reaction to the image, focusing on which specific parts evoke that response and why
- Think about your own reaction and evaluate the effectiveness of the image What is the purpose or goal of the visual? To convince you (not) do something? To (not) think a certain way? Does the visual achieve this goal?

When you are analyzing the composition of an image, consider how the following compositional elements are being used:

- **Audience:** for whom is the image being designed? Where might the audience encounter it?
- **Purpose:** what is the point or goal of this image?
- **Bias:** what biases (prejudices or clear points of view) are being represented in the image? Which are not?
- **Tone:** what is the tone of the image? Is it meant to be funny? serious? satirical?
- **Text:** if there is text in the image, what does it say literally? What does it imply?
- **Colour:** is the image in black and white? greyscale? full colour? How does this change our perception or understanding?
- **Message:** what comment or point is the illustrator trying to make? Does it come across (is it conveyed) effectively? Why or why not?
- **Symbolism:** symbolism is an artistic and poetic movement or style using



A swastika

symbolic images and indirect suggestion to express mystical ideas, emotions, and states of mind. The meaning of a symbol is constructed socially. For example, in Buddhism, the swastika is a symbol of good fortune, prosperity, abundance and eternity; then, in World War 2, Hitler appropriated it as a symbol for the Third Reich, so it has come to be a negative symbol in Western cultures.

- **Metaphor:** a metaphor is a figure of speech in which a word or phrase is applied to an object or action to which it is not literally applicable. For example, if someone says “you’re a peach,” a comparison is being drawn between that person and a peach, but not literally. It actually implies that the person is sweet (kind), like a peach. The meaning behind metaphors is a social construction, and therefore typically by a given community or culture.
- **Negative space:** negative space is the empty or blank space around and between objects that can call attention to certain elements of an image. It can also be used to guide the eye of the viewer in a certain direction.
- **Allusions:** when an image uses knowledge that is presupposed on the part of the viewer; in other words, the illustrator assumes that the audience will have a basic understanding of the implied reference.

Practice Exercise

Political cartoons are a popular way to express ideas in a quick, visual format. Examine the political cartoon below by Greg Perry (if you don’t understand the reference, look up Doug Ford’s “buck-a-beer” program).

How do the compositional elements outlined above help to create larger meaning in this image? What is the message that Perry is trying to convey with this cartoon?

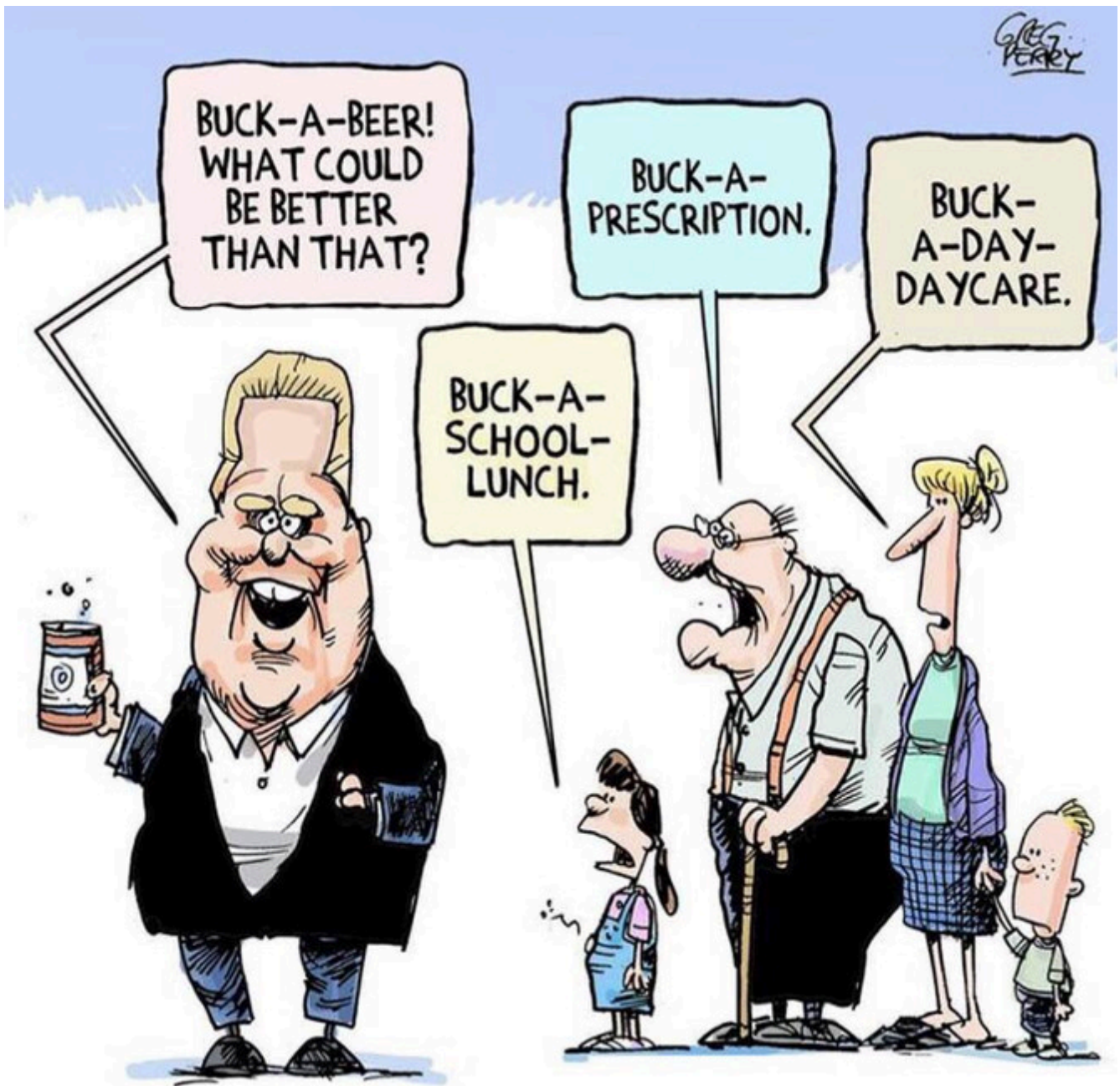


Image source: <https://socialistproject.ca/2018/08/fords-attack-on-toronto-end-of-local-democracy/>

Practice Exercise

Examine the 2010 advertisement below and, using the analytical strategies above, analyze the effectiveness of this advertisement. Does the ad achieve its purpose? How so and why?



Image source: <https://www.peta.org/features/pamela-anderson-shows-animals-same-parts/>

Giving Presentations: Understanding Audience, Purpose, and Style

Just as essays have different forms to suit different purposes, so do presentations. Knowing the type of presentation you will be giving helps you to tailor your content and style to the audience and situation. Is your presentation meant to entertain people and be funny? Is it meant to inspire and motivate others? Is it more academic and designed to inform or educate an audience? Or perhaps you're going on a job interview and you need to present yourself as the best candidate for the role?

Each of these scenarios will warrant a different approach and style in your presentation. Let's take a look at a few different models.

Informative/Professional

- Examples: Work Training Seminar or Client Product Pitch
- Purpose: To cover specific and required information in order to educate or convince the audience to adopt/use a

particular approach or product.

- Style: Business Casual to Formal. Depending on who the audience is, you may find that the level of formality changes. It can be helpful to confer with teammates or a superior to determine how formal a presentation is intended to be. For example, it is expected that in Canadian courts of law, judges will wear robes in the court but may then remove them during a discussion in private chambers.

Motivational

- Examples: Public Speaking Events or Fundraising Events
- Purpose: To share inspiring ideas and personal experience in an attempt to motivate others to a course of action.
- Style: Casual to Semi-Formal. Typically with motivational speaking, the emphasis is on creating an emotional connection with the audience through stories and accounts of lived experiences. If the event has a dress code or certain expectations (black-tie or a uniform, for example), you should adhere to them.

Academic

- Examples: Conference/Project Presentation or Leading a Seminar
- Purpose: To have an informed discussion that has a clear goal and/or point being made. Points should be supported with evidence and cited properly.
- Style: Semi-formal to Formal. Conference presentations are more formal and require you to dress in business casual. Presentations in a classroom are typically more semi-formal and can be done in regular clothes.

Interview

- Examples: Job Interview or Citizenship Interview
- Purpose: To demonstrate particular knowledge, allow the interviewer get to know you personally, and to verify credibility/credentials.
- Style: Formal. Be sure to come prepared with copies of relevant documents and ready to answer questions related to the situation. This is a situation where you are being evaluated, so you want to appear as professional as possible.

Giving Effective Presentations

At its core, a good presentation is an *engaging* presentation; that is to say, effective presentations invite the audience to listen and interact with the content by making it relative to them.

Here are some strategies that you can work on to help make your presentations engaging for the audience:

- Begin with an **agenda** that allows the audience to know the general plan for your session.
- Ask open-ended and closed-ended **questions** to engage the audience. You could ask for their thoughts or opinions on a subject, or even something as simple as a hands up vote.
- Invite **discussion** around debatable topics or issues.
- Incorporate **multimedia**, such as videos, pictures, or handouts, into your presentation.
- Keep slides or other **presentation media clear** and easy to read (make sure it's not too busy and can be followed by everyone).
- If possible, **move around the room** to help keep the energy up.
- **Moderate your voice** (don't talk too fast or too slow) and take frequent pauses to allow the audience to process

what you are saying. Remember: you may have rehearsed the presentation ten times, but this is the *first* time most people will be hearing your content. They need time to process.

- Create a **space for questions** (on chart paper, the white board, sticky notes, etc) that may not be relevant in the moment, but that you want to come back to later.
- Make **eye-contact** with the audience and **don't rely on cue cards** or prepared notes. The more “organic” a presentation feels, the more the audience can engage. Make sure that you rehearse, but don't become fixated on reading everything like a script.

Helpful hints to consider:

- In most cases, the audience hasn't seen/heard your material. They likely won't know if you forget to make a point. If it's important that you include something that you have missed, just circle back. A great way to do this seamlessly is to say something like: “One point that I would like to stress here is _____”
- If you have trouble looking people directly in the eyes, focus on their noses instead. They will get the impression that you're looking at them, but you don't have to make direct eye contact.
- If you don't know the answer to a question, speculate. For example, you might say in response “that's a good question, but it was outside the scope of my research. However, based upon what I do know about this topic, I would speculate that _____.” Try to avoid using the “let me do some research and get back to you” line (since no one ever does and you may not have the opportunity to do so).
- Use your slides or other presentation media as your cue cards. If you know the topic well enough, the slides will help you remember the flow and main points you want to make. From there, you can just talk about the topic.

Key Terms and Concepts

- Medium (pl. media)
- Media Literacy
- Digital Literacy
- Digital Native
- Digital Immigrant
- Visual Analysis
- Composition Techniques (types of)
- Presentations (types of)

5. Preparing for Assignments: The Research Process

Chapter 5 Content Summary:

- Research Assignments
- Types of Research
- Primary Research
- Secondary Research
- The Research Process (including Questions & Thesis Statements)
- Research Proposals
- Annotated Bibliographies

What is a Research Assignment?

Simply put, a **research assignment** requires you to find information from a variety of different sources (see **Chapter 3** on **Evidence**). Your research assignment could ask you to conduct **primary research** (where you generate your own data, such as creating and administering a survey), **secondary research** (where you use the data that other people have provided in professional/academic sources), or a combination of both types of research. A research assignment also does not have to be a traditional essay. Many academic disciplines require that research be conducted for projects such as podcasts, art installations, articles, creative stories, photo essays, presentations, reports, journals, lab write-ups, etc. In short, most of the work that you will do in post-secondary will be some form of research assignment. In fact, unless your professors indicate otherwise, it is a good idea to always assume that you are required to find secondary sources to support your assignments.

Research assignments can be daunting, particularly if you don't know how or where to begin the process. This chapter builds upon the content in **Chapter 4** and focuses on just that – getting you through the research process with as minimal stress as possible.

Reflection Exercise

Read the following assignment prompt (taken from a [real classroom](#) context) and imagine that you are being

asked to complete it for one of your classes. Consider the process (the specific steps) that you would go through – from start to finish – in order to do it. Jot down your ideas and compare them with someone around you.

Did you have the same steps in the same order? Does one way make more sense? Why?

2000 Word Essay Assignment Prompt

The paper should be 2000 words plus or minus 10% (i.e. it should fall between 1800-2200 words), excluding footnotes.

A list of suggested topics include:

1. Comparison between two different religions covered in class, outlining important differences and similarities between both religions. One must come from a Western tradition and one from an Eastern tradition.

Example: comparing Buddhism and Judaism.

2. Choose an emerging branch of a religion present in America today and outline its origin and development, and how it differs from other branches of that religion.

Example: Mormonism and how this relates to earlier forms of Christianity.

3. Discuss how colonisation has impacted on different religions around the world.

Example: Hinduism following the British colonial period.

Students should choose a topic and decide on a more specific concentration for their paper within this topic, such as the examples given above. Students must then email me to have the chosen topic and specific concentration confirmed, to ensure that there is an even spread of students taking each topic and no duplications of specific concentrations. Topics and concentrations will be assigned on a first come first served basis. The deadline for having these finalised is 10th July. On this date, students are expected to share their topic and concentration with the rest of the class and briefly talk about the direction their essay will take.

Depending on the nature of the assignment and the prompt that your instructor has provided, you may start at different points in this process; however, if you were to speak with your professors, you would find that there is a fairly common method for approaching the **research process**.

The Research Process

1. **Review the assignment requirements** to ensure that you understand what you are being asked to do. Make sure to reflect on any verbs being used.

2. **Determine the topic.** This may have already been provided to you by your professor, you may have been given some choices for a framework, or you may have been told simply to hand in _____ (an essay, presentation, reflection, etc).

3. **Conduct some preliminary research.** Google your topic and get a sense of what it's about. If you are completely unfamiliar with the topic, this step will be essential. If you already have a solid grasp on the topic, move ahead to step 4:

4. **Establish scope, context, and subtopic.** **Scope** is what you will (and will not) cover in the assignment. **Context** relates to the circumstances around the topic. What do we (not) already know about it? **Subtopic** refers to the concentration of particular focus of your topic – in the sample assignment prompt from the Reflection Exercise above, the examples under each topic are the subtopics.

5. **Generate a research question.** This step is perhaps one of the most important parts of the research process. Your research question will – typically – attempt to generate **inductive lines of argument** (see **Chapter 2**), which will enable debate and discussion of that topic. One way to think about generating a research question is to think in terms of **What** and **Why/How**:

The **What** is your context – it's where you can define your terms and bring incorporate the information that you established in step 4. Most of the time, this part of the research question can be answered quickly and in about half a page. If your topic was video game addiction, your **What** could be something as simple as: "What is video game addiction?" This question is not as easy to answer as it may first appear. Ask yourself at what point someone is addicted to anything – there is often little consensus about defining addiction, but we can often recognize it when we see it. This means that you will need to provide a working definition or threshold for your paper to determine when someone is addicted to video games.

The **Why/How** is your significance (or the inductive part of your argument). This part is the researchable stuff – the meat of a research paper – and it enables you to have an informed discussion or debate. Consider our previous example of video game addiction:

What is video game addiction?

Why or How does it affect the _____ in Canada? (ex. cognitive development of children; rising rates of school violence; the social development of teenagers, etc)

Why is this step so crucial? It sets you up to be successful in the next stage: Conducting Research.

STUDENT TIP: If you often find yourself with little to say or repeating the same ideas and points in your assignment, you likely need to come back to the Research Question stage and rework some things. These problems typically arise when a student has a *What?* but not a *Why/How?* part to help develop significance.

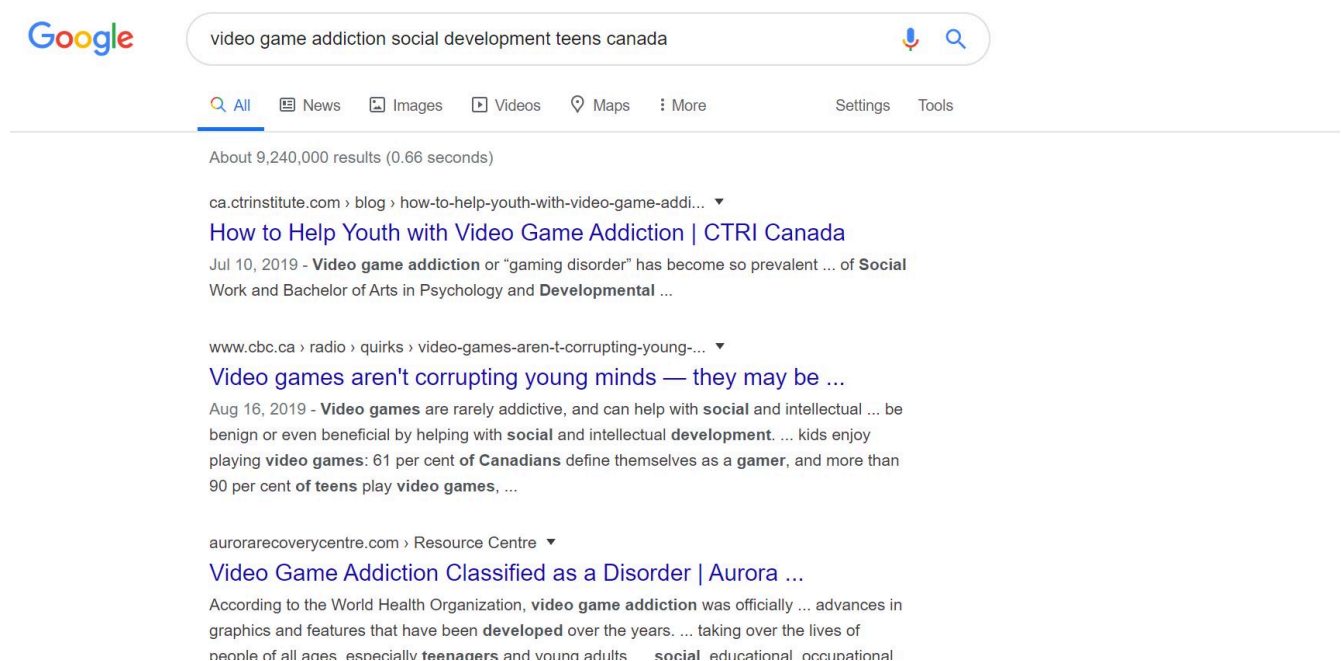
6. **Conducting Research.** Let's continue with our example of video game addiction and suppose that we are going to use the following research question:

What is video game addiction and how does it affect the social development of teenagers in Canada?

To begin your research, you would use search terms that come from your **research question**:

- video game
- addiction
- social development
- teenagers
- Canada

Depending on what requirements your professor has set in terms of using professional vs. scholarly academic sources, you have a couple of options: 1. Google your topic, or 2. Search the Library databases.



Sheridan Library and Learning Services

video game addiction social development teens canada

1,327 results sorted by relevance

REFINE YOUR SEARCH

Full Text Online
Peer-Review
Library Catalogue

CONTENT TYPE

Newspaper Article (736)
Journal Article (352)
Magazine Article (93)
Book-Review (58)
Book Chapter (37)
More...

PUBLICATION DATE

1 **online** Online **social** networking and addiction--a review of the psychological literature
by Kuss, Daria J.; Griffiths, Mark D.
International journal of environmental research and public health, 09/2011, Volume 8, Issue 9
Social Networking Sites (SNSs) are virtual communities where users can create individual public profiles, interact with real-life friends, and meet other people based on shared interests...
Journal Article: Full Text Online
Permitted Uses
Preview

2 **online** Do problematic and non-problematic **video game** players differ in extraversion, trait empathy, **social** capital and prosocial...
by Collins, Emily; Freeman, Jonathan
Computers in Human Behavior, 09/2013, Volume 29, Issue 5

COVID-19
In response to COVID-19, all library spaces are closed and all services have moved to remote-first delivery.
Chat with Us during regular service hours.
Email Us anytime
Current Updates for a list of our current services and resources.

Digital Learning Resources
Access our digital teaching and learning resources wherever you happen to study or work
Digital Learning Resources

Working Remotely

There are several goals connected to finding research that is relevant to your topic:

- Help you to understand what has been said about the topic, including common or shared positions and points of view.
- Supply you with evidence to help support your own arguments and discussion about the topic.
- Equip you with the knowledge that you will need to address and counter opposing arguments.
- Provide the information necessary to answer your research question and form your thesis statement.

7. The Thesis Statement. A common misconception about the thesis statement is that it must be only a single sentence. While it can be one sentence depending (depending on the length of the paper), it's important to understand that when we say "thesis statement," we mean *statement* in the following context: "a definite or clear expression of something in speech or writing" (Google). The thesis statement can – and often should – be more than one sentence that **answers your research question** and should be the **main point of the assignment**. The research findings and data that you accumulate in the Conducting Research stage are how you go about answering that question.

Depending on the style of assignment you are doing, you will need to use different styles of thesis statements. The University of Guelph identifies several types of thesis statements:

5 TYPES OF THESIS STATEMENTS

What is a thesis statement?

A thesis statement identifies the main point or central idea of your paper.

Where should I put it?

In most, but not all, academic papers, your thesis will be explicitly stated in one or two sentences near the beginning of your paper.

Here are some examples of the most common thesis statements:



ARGUMENT: State a point of view and support it with evidence

Parts: Topic + position + reasons

Example: Volunteer tourism in southeast Asia [topic] should be more strictly regulated [position] to prevent economic, social, and cultural exploitation [reasons].



EVALUATION: Assess strengths and weaknesses

Parts: Evaluation + reasons

Example: Abraham Poincheval's installation, *Pierre*, is a landmark in performance art [evaluation], not just because of its unique concept--a man living inside of a rock--but also because of the unique and deeply-felt responses it evokes from visitors of all ages [reasons].



ANALYSIS: Examine the components of a text, object, or idea, and discuss how these components work together

Parts: Component(s) + effect(s) they produce

Example: In *Jane Eyre*, the use of supernatural elements, mythic references, and fairy tale motifs [components] contribute to a sense of unease throughout the book, making a conventionally happy ending implausible [effect].



COMPARISON: Examine the similarities and differences of texts, objects, or ideas

Parts: Objects of comparison + conclusion

Example: A comparison of the mechanisms and outcomes of immunotherapy and chemotherapy [objects of comparison] shows that immunotherapies are more effective in treating cancer and cause fewer harmful side effects for cancer patients [conclusion].



CAUSE AND EFFECT: Focus on how actions or events contributed to specific outcomes

Parts: Cause(s) + effect(s)

Example: Many people believe the Great Depression was the result of the Stock Market Crash of 1929; however, the economic crisis in Canada [effect] was worsened by global trade agreements and government inaction [causes].



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Based upon the information that was provided in your assignment prompt, you will need to choose the type of thesis statement that is most appropriate.

8. Outlining the project. If you are writing a traditional argumentative essay, this part of the process may prove to be the most challenging of all; however, *everyone outlines before writing* – some people may not recognize what it is that they are doing, though. While many people use essay outlining templates, doodle, mind maps (or idea webs), a point form list, some people do the process mentally. When people outline an essay is as different as how they do it. Some people prefer to outline before they write anything down, some outline as they write, some outline as they research. The important part is figuring out a system that works for you and helps you to conceptualize your project most effectively.

Research Proposals

Research proposals are a valuable tool that help you conceive of and work through your research assignment in advance of writing. Proposals are a means to get feedback from your professors before you get too far into your research and encounter complications that could waste too much time. Think of them as an early warning system that helps the professor to guide you more effectively as you work on a research project.

A research proposal should provide a detailed plan for your assignment. You might be required to do a proposal or pitch in a very specific way for both post-secondary studies and in your career. There is no one correct format for a research proposal, which is why you will most often be given directions or a template by your professors or employers. However, most research proposals cover fairly consistent information:

- Timeline (if applicable – typically for long-term projects)
- Topic + Subtopic
- Thesis statement
- Main points or lines of argument
- Summary of research findings, including key evidence
- Literature or sources consulted (typically presented as a **bibliography**)

Annotated Bibliographies

An annotated bibliography is a list of summaries of sources you have consulted for the purpose of a standalone project or as a part of a larger research project. The list is presented as a reference page (or works cited page, bibliography, etc, depending on the referencing style you are required to use). Depending on your assignment guidelines, aside from giving a concise summary (called an **annotation**) underneath each reference entry, you may also have to indicate why you have decided to use this source, mention why the source is relevant, and/or evaluate the reliability and credibility of the source.

Check with your professor's instructions regarding:

- Number of sources needed,
- Length of each entry,
- Types of sources (scholarly, professional),
- Font and page layout,
- Citation style to use (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc)

IMPORTANT: requirements for an annotated bibliography will vary depending on the nature of your assignment, the learning outcomes of the course, and the goals of the professor. It's critical that you pay close attention to the assignment outline and the instructions given in class.

Always Include:

A Bibliographic Citation	• List your sources following a standard citation style (ex. APA style) • Alphabetize your list by author's last name
An Annotation	• Write your annotation in paragraph format • Provide a summary of the scope, main points, and central theme of the article • Describe any conclusions that can be drawn from the article • Comment on the intended audience • Compare or contrast this source with another you have cited • Point out any notable biases or gaps you detect • Evaluate and explain why this source is relevant or suitable for your topic

Writing Annotated Bibliographies

In the annotated bibliography, you will briefly restate the main argument of your source. The easiest way you can do this is by identifying the thesis/research question, methods, and conclusions of your source. Once again, you will not be merely listing these findings but recognizing why these key points are related to the overall argument.

So, as you read be sure to locate the thesis/research question – you will want to take a close look at the introduction and conclusion of your source. Glance over the entire source and be mindful of headings and how the text has been organized – pay special attention to the topic sentences of paragraphs. Identify the methods used to investigate the issues brought up in the research. Watch out for the repetition of terms and ideas, including signal phrases that indicate larger ideas and important points.

Illustrating the Importance of your Source

After you have successfully summarized the argument of your source you will have to focus on why the research is relevant and valuable. The next step will be to identify the role this source will play in your own research project and why it is useful to you.

This part of your annotation will briefly **assess** the value of your source regarding its **usefulness** in supporting your thesis and paper. If you are working on a research project, briefly identify how you intend to use the source and why. If your bibliography is an independent project, try to assess the source's contribution to the research on your topic. Is it valuable because of the methods it uses to come to its conclusions? Is it because it interprets the problem uniquely? Does it contain specific evidence you are interested in using? These are just some of the questions you could answer – there can be many different reasons as to why you have chosen a particular source.

The website [Harvard Writes](#) lists seven ways in which a source can be used in your writing:

1. **Establish what's at stake:** *a source provides a problem or question, and provides a sense of what's at stake in your*

argument

2. **Provide context:** *a source explains what the reader needs to understand about the background of your topic in order for your argument to make sense*
3. **Provide support:** *when you want to make an argument about your topic, you can cite a scholarly source that has a similar perspective to help back up your claim*
4. **Provide keywords:** *a source provides a definition or central concept/term that will help your reader to understand your own argument*
5. **Provide counter-argument:** *a source provides a different point of view or perspective to your own argument, which you can then use to counter-argue*
6. **Advance your own argument:** *a source provides information that can help you develop your own argument further by offering new insights or ideas to your discussion*
7. **Complicate your own argument:** *a source presents a complication to your own line of argument; useful to take into account in order to convince your readers that you have considered multiple perspectives on your topic and gives you a basis from which to counter-argue*

Formatting

In addition to citations and a reference page, you are also required to format your document in accordance with reference style guidelines. The typically accepted standard for formatting your document in is as follows:

- Times New Roman font
- Size 12
- 1 inch margins
- Double spaced
- Be sure to include a title page and/or header, based upon the requirements of the reference style you are using

IMPORTANT: The formatting of your annotated bibliography will depend on which style your instructor has requested you use. Confirm that you are meeting the citation style guides so that you can format your bibliography correctly.

SAMPLE APA ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY ENTRY:

Shimo, A. (2006, April 25). The rise of private care in Canada. *Maclean's*. Retrieved from http://www.macleans.ca/article.jsp?content=20060501_125881_125881

This magazine article looks at the rapidly growing private health care services across Canada. It follows the recent developments made by a number of provinces to widen private health care practices. These privatized services would allow Canadians to pay for quicker and enhanced access to family doctors and several procedures. The article explores the role private care currently plays in Canada and how the population's steadily dissatisfied opinion of public health care will impact its future. The growing demand and strenuousness of our public health system is targeted as the catalyst for the growth of privatization. Shimo's article hints that the private and public health care sectors will need to co-exist to ensure the health of Canadians allows for less congestion and advanced treatments and technologies to be an option. This article is valuable as it outlines the ways in which Canadian provinces are dealing with the existing health care problems and I will use it to reinforce address the opposite side of my argument in my paper.

Key Terms and Concepts

- Research Assignment
- Primary Research
- Secondary Research
- Scope
- Context
- Subtopic
- Research Question
- Thesis Statement
- Outlining
- Research Proposal
- Annotated Bibliography

6. Parts of the Essay and Argumentative Models

Chapter 6 Content Summary:

- The Five-Paragraph Essay Model
- Types of Essay
- Reflective and Critique Essays
- Argumentative Essays (including Toulmin & Rogerian Models)
- Writing Strong Body Paragraphs
- Writing Introductions and Conclusions

The Five-Paragraph Essay Model? Not so much...

For those who are familiar with the 5-Paragraph Essay model, the following will look familiar (and may even make you shudder):

Five Paragraph Outline

Paragraph 1	Introduction • Thesis Statement • Briefly summarize your three topic sentences
Paragraph 2	Topic Sentence Elaborate on your topic sentence Provide an example/evidence/quotation Explain the significance of the example/evidence/quotation
Paragraph 3	Topic Sentence Elaborate on your topic sentence Provide an example/evidence/quotation Explain the significance of the example/evidence/quotation
Paragraph 4	Topic Sentence Elaborate on your topic sentence Provide an example/evidence/quotation Explain the significance of the example/evidence/quotation
Paragraph 2	Conclusion • Summarize your three topic sentences • Discuss how the ideas in paragraphs 2-4 support your thesis

A Sample Five-Paragraph Essay Source: <https://jodimiller.wordpress.com/skills/how-to-write-an-essay-2/sample-5-paragraph-essay-outline/>

The Five-Paragraph essay model is a favourite amongst high school teachers in North America and in other parts of the world. When the subject of the Five-Paragraph essay comes up in post-secondary classrooms, it's not uncommon to see students become confused, anxious, and even scared when professors tell them that there is *no such rule for essay writing*. Think about things that you've read outside of your past English classes – was it only five paragraphs long? Likely not. Some essays may end up being five paragraphs long based upon the assignment requirements, but that is *not a rule for all essay writing*.

If you've ever been asked to write using this model, you may have found it awkward, clunky, disjointed, or confusing. That's likely because the Five-Paragraph essay sometimes forces students to cram ideas and points into paragraphs in a contrived manner that sabotages and constrains the **flow** of an essay (the order of the paragraphs and the structure within them that helps to organize your thoughts, ideas, and evidence) because the model isn't sufficient enough to capture long, complex analysis. This isn't to say that the Five-Paragraph model is "bad" or not useful – there are many instances where you will be required to convey information and ideas in a limited amount of space and the fundamentals of this model will be important; however in post-secondary, where much of your work will involve research and analysis, a Five-Paragraph essay is often far too restrictive and short for academic purposes. In order to be able to adapt your

writing to the essay and argumentative models that are discussed in this chapter, you will find that your essay will likely have to move beyond the five-paragraph essay model – it’s an expectation in post-secondary studies.

Understanding Essay Styles: Know Thy Purpose

As we’ve already covered in this book, in order to understand a college assignment, you need to understand the verbs being used because they are the embedded instructions that tell you what you need to do. Essay styles are similar: each style or model has a different purpose. Let’s first consider what an essay actually is before we get into different types of essays:

Essay: a short literary composition on a particular theme or subject, usually in prose and generally analytic, speculative, or interpretative.

Source: <https://www.dictionary.com/browse/essay>

So, while the idea of writing an essay can be daunting to many people, at its core, an essay is just a piece of writing. We all have opinions and ideas about the world around us: essays just help us to order, classify, and convey these ideas to a larger audience in a recognizable form.

Below is a table that summarizes some of the most common types of essays and their goals.

ESSAY STYLE	PURPOSE
Expository	Sometimes called an <i>informative essay</i> . Investigates an idea or concept from multiple sides or angles. Analyzes evidence and expound upon the ideas. Draws conclusions from research and discuss the topic at length to inform the audience. Evaluates ideas, situations, concepts, or subjects, often with the intent to assess the effectiveness of the topic.
Argumentative	Chooses a position and convince the reader that your stance is correct. Presents and analyzes evidence to demonstrate that your argument is valid and makes the most sense.
Reflective & Critique	Also called a <i>critical analysis essay</i> . Considers how or why a particular event or object impacted you directly. Often requires students to apply disciplinary theories and concepts in order to present insights within a critical framework.
Narrative	Uses a story or personal experience to convey your points, ideas, and insights about a situation or topic. The goal is to entertain the audience and demonstrate the importance of the particular event or experience.
Compare & Contrast	Looks at the similarities and differences between two or more subjects. Assesses the strengths/weaknesses or benefits/drawbacks of each subject within the context of a larger purpose or goal.

It is worth stating this in bold: **all forms of essay should contain a thesis**. Even a narrative essay, which relies upon storytelling, will have a main purpose/idea/goal that the reader should take away. And simply put, that’s really all that a thesis statement is: the main message that you want to leave with your audience.

While there are many different modes of essay writing, essays should all contain some common elements, which include:

- A title page or header (depending on your professor's preferred style)
- An introduction that contains a thesis statement
- Organized body paragraphs
- A conclusion
- A reference page and in-text citations for any external sources used
- Typed in an appropriately sized, legible font (you wouldn't believe some of the things your professors have seen in this category...)
- Use appropriate evidence and rhetorical appeals that match the purpose of the essay. For example, pathos is a much more useful appeal in a narrative essay than it is in an expository essay.

While all essay forms are useful and important to understand, this text will focus on two in particular: Reflective & Critique Essays and Argumentative Essay. These are likely the two most popular models that you will encounter at college, so it's worth spending a bit of time getting better acquainted with them.

Reflective & Critique Essays

Reflective and Critique essays are common in the humanities, particularly when an assessment of art is involved (creative writing, literature, photography, fine arts, drama, theatre, music, animation, craft and design, etc). The idea of a critique or reflection essay is to speak to the ability of the art to have an impact or achieve a (sometimes pre-established) purpose.

Critiques and Reflections should be as **specific and concrete** as possible. We see a lot of "cause and effect" language in these forms of writing (ex. "the use of ____ make me feel/think ____ because ____"). There is a helpful model that originates in art criticism that assists students in working through how to conduct a critique called [Edmund Feldman's Method of Art Criticism](#):

1. Description *Be 100% objective / Think of facts -What specific Elements of Art (color, line, shape, texture, form, space, value) can you find within this piece? -What's the title of the artwork? -Who is the artist? -When/where was it created? -What media was used? -Is there a primary subject in the piece?	2. Analysis *Be 100% objective / Think of facts -What Principles of Art (balance, emphasis, movement, pattern, repetition, proportion, etc.) can you find within this piece? -How do the Elements of Art interact with each other? Are there interesting visual effects created? -What specific elements stand out in this composition and why? Is there a focal point? -How is the work organized?	<i>Edmund Feldman's Method of Art Criticism</i>
3. Interpretation *Subjective / Requires thought on your part -What is the artist trying to communicate? -What thoughts or feelings come up when you see this piece? *Abstract works quite frequently require us to learn more about the context the work was created in (artist's life and time/place in history) in order to better understand them. -Express your opinion, but ALWAYS back it up with evidence.	4. Judgement *Subjective / Requires thought on your part -Finally, you can share personal thoughts based on previous steps. -Do you like it? Why/why not? Again, use solid evidence to support your opinion. -Is this piece effective? Is it saying what the artist is intending to say? -Are you judging based on technique or emotional content? What criteria do YOU think are important when judging an artwork?	

Feldman's method seeks to assess the effectiveness of art by considering and analyzing the various compositional elements. However, the same method can also be adapted for more sociological or scientific environments, such as writing a self-reflective essay on a field placement or co-op experience; instead of describing a form of art, you would describe a situation or experiment and move through the four stages.

Essays in the reflective and critique style are about using knowledge that you have acquired in order to demonstrate **insight** into your field of practice, situations you encounter, and even your self.

Argumentative Essays

The argumentative essay is perhaps the most recognized form of essays amongst students at various levels of education. The goal of an argumentative essay is to investigate a topic and persuade the reader in some capacity: persuade that your view is correct, persuade to compromise, persuade to a course of action, etc.

The argumentative essay should take a reader through the major points of an issue or topic in a systematic way that allows the author to support a thesis (which in argumentative essays is often a **subjective claim** – an assertion that something *should* exist and present evidence derived from ethical, moral, or aesthetic convictions) in a convincing and compelling manner.

What follows are two specific styles of argumentative essay: the Toulmin Model and the Rogerian Model. While the rhetorical strategies of these two forms are quite different, they share the goal of engaging in forms of persuasion and debate.

Toulmin Model of Argument

Stephen Toulmin (1922-2009), an English philosopher of science and this history of ideas, developed a system of argument that has proven useful and influential in the modern world of complex rhetorical situations where problems are not easily divided into “right” and “wrong.” Toulmin's model of argument is systematic in its reasoning; at the same time, it demands that this reasoning be scrutinized for its ethical underpinnings. It is not enough to present a claim and try to “prove it” with evidence. The arguer must also examine the evidence itself to scrutinize the assumptions we make about the evidence and even to ensure that *those* assumptions are similarly scrutinized for their ethical underpinnings. Toulmin argument, then, insists that logic alone cannot resolve complex human issues. Ethics and values play as important a role in argumentation as logical reasoning.

The Toulmin Model of Argument

The terms that we encounter in the Toulmin model immediately call attention to the complexity of the social interaction required for responsible argumentation:

- An argument begins with a **claim** to be made, which must be articulated as clearly and as accurately as possible, keeping in mind that problems are often more complicated than they seem to be on the surface. The claim is the thesis or premise of your argument that you want your audience to accept.
- To accomplish this goal, you must produce compelling **data**, the grounds or evidence. It is important to keep in mind that “evidence” means different things in different disciplines. In the sciences, for example, the data probably consist of results obtained from experiments, close observations, or mathematical analyses. In other contexts, the data probably consists of rules, laws, policies, highly valued social customs, or quotations from works

of literature.

- Next, you need to ask of any argument whether the data used to support the claim truly are valid and are based on a sound sense of values. In other words, you must determine one or more underlying *warrants*, assurances that the data are based on some sensible and ethical foundation. Anyone can conjure up all sorts of data and manipulate it to give the appearance of validating a claim. For example, sometimes it is not enough to cite a law; it may be necessary to decide if the law is just or unjust.
- Just as the validity of the data is reinforced and sanctioned by one or more underlying warrants, so too must the validity of the warrants be reinforced. As Stephen Toulmin himself explains in *An Introduction to Reasoning* (1979), “Warrants are not self-validating ... [and] normally draw their strength and solidity from further substantial supporting considerations” (58). These further supporting considerations Toulmin calls *backing*. To return to the example of unjust laws, the arguer would need to ask: What *assurance* can I give that the law is unjust?
- Finally, you must be prepared to bring in one or more *qualifiers* to your claim – that is, be prepared to call attention to any exceptions to the claim under certain circumstances. Consider: “The right to free speech must be protect in all situations except when it can endanger life or safety, such as yelling ‘Fire!’ in a crowded theater.” The qualifier – the exception to the rule – prevents the claim from losing touch with complex social situations. The ability to anticipate qualifiers to one’s claim is the mark of a responsible arguer. Toulmin refers to this phase of argument as the *rebuttal*. Of course, no arguer can anticipate every possible exception, and that is why audience feedback is so important in argumentation.

The Claim

You know this feature as the thesis, premise, or central assumption. Toulmin chooses to call it the *claim* because that term suggests a thesis or assertion that is particularly *open to challenge*. For an argument to succeed, the writer must first ensure that the claim offered is worthy of deliberation. Some claims are not arguable. For example, it would be foolish to argue seriously that, in general, red is a superior colour to blue. The claim is too dependent on subjective taste to be arguable. But let’s say you are an interior decorator and you have studied the effects of colour on mood. You might argue that particular colours work best in particular types of rooms within a house. Here the claim is not based on personal taste but on research studies: data collected has shown that pale blue helps relax people; therefore, pale blue would be an appropriate choice for bedroom walls.

As we know, there are two basic types of claims: objective and subjective. *Objective claims* assert that something *actually* exists and present evidence that is demonstrably factual – not only in the sense of scientifically factual but legally factual, as in the case of laws, regulations, and policies. Here are some examples of objective claims:

- Video games heighten a child’s hand-eye coordination and visual perception, but they impede the development of language processing skills.
- It is a myth that science is based only on logical reasoning and that art is based only on imagination. Logical reasoning and imagination are equally important to science and art.
- YouTube provides new artists opportunities to be seen by and signed to major recording companies.

These claims present themselves as objective truths, but they are not *self-evident* truths; they must be supported with the appropriate evidence before readers can accept them as valid. Thus, before the first claim (above) can be accepted as valid, the arguer must show, for example, that psychologists have compared the learning behaviours of children who play video games with those who do not and have found enough evidence to establish a causal link between video-game playing and abstract reasoning.

Before the second claim (above) can be accepted as valid, the arguer must provide convincing examples of the way imagination works in science and the way logical reasoning works in art. For example, the arguer might refer to

autobiographical statements of scientists such as Albert Einstein or mathematicians such as Jules Henri Poincaré, who at various times, obtained scientific understanding through dreams or imaginary “thought experiments.”

As was mentioned in the introduction to this section on argumentative essays, *subjective claims* assert that something *should* exist and present evidence derived from ethical, moral, or aesthetic convictions. Someone who argues, for example, that all college students should be required to take at least one course in composition in order to graduate or that animals should be treated with dignity is making a subjective claim. Although each claim is based on personal values, one cannot dismiss them as a kind of anything-goes relativism. The arguer, for example, might demonstrate that the benefits derived from studying composition improve one’s ability to understand human nature, a valuable asset when one interacts with people.

The Data or Grounds

The Toulmin model demands that writers take pains to ensure that the supporting evidence fully validates the claim. The word *data* suggests “hard facts” – results from experiments or statistics from surveys, as well as historical, legal, and biographical facts. For more indirect kinds of evidence, such as testimonials or interpretations, the term *grounds* is more appropriate.

Like claims, data or grounds must be presented as accurately and as unambiguously as possible. Someone who argues, for example, that essay exams test student comprehension of literature better than multiple-choice exams do, and who in so arguing relies on the testimonials of students, would want to make sure that those testimonials contain clear *demonstrations* of better comprehension for students taking essay exams. Of course, the criteria for “better comprehension” would need to be clarified before they could be used as valid grounds for a claim.

The Warrant and its Backing

A warrant is the assurance that the evidence brought in to support the claim is completely reliable and that it rests on sound principles or values. Thus, just as the data legitimate the claim, a warrant, often implicit in the argument, legitimate the data. As Stephen Toulmin writes in *The Uses of Argument*, warrants “indicate the bearing of [the] conclusion of the data already produced” (98). By “bearing,” Toulmin is referring to the need for readers to recognize and accept an appropriate direction in which the argument takes shape from claim to data to warrant. Warrants remind us of the humanizing dimension of argument: An argument, no matter how “heated,” must always be principled rather than stem from vague or questionable motives.

Let us see how warrants operate in a given argument. Consider an essay in which a student, Rajdeep, argues for the abolition of letter grades in formal education. Rajdeep’s claim is as follows:

Letter grades should be abolished because they result in unhealthy competition, distract students from truly learning the subject matter, and constitute an inadequate gauge of student performance.

Melissa chooses to support her claim with data that compare the performance of students in a letter-graded class with the performance of students in a Pass/No Pass class. Melissa’s warrant might go something like this: “Learning for its own sake is more satisfying to students than learning to achieve predetermined standards of proficiency.” As backing for this warrant, Melissa might conclude something like the following: “The more satisfying the learning experience, the more students are likely to learn.” Melissa may not need to state these sentences explicitly, but the evidence she uses to support her claim should make the warrant and backing apparent.

Compelling warrants are just as vital to the force of an argument as are compelling data because they reinforce

the trustworthiness of the data. Unsuccessful warrants often seem disconnected from, or even contradictory to, the evidence. Consider the following claim:

Students should not be required to attend class.

If the evidence presented is the college's pledge to inculcate self-reliance in students, then the warrant – the conviction that self-reliance is compromised when professors require students to attend class – would seem contradictory to many readers because it is often assumed that such requirements are designed to *promote* self-reliance. Similarly, backing can be faulty. For example, in an argument claiming that every sixteen-year-old who drops out of school should be denied a driver's license, a warrant might involve the conviction that there is never any legitimate justification for dropping out of school; however, it would be difficult to find backing for this warrant that would apply in every circumstance.

There are three kinds of warrants, which roughly correspond to the three kinds of rhetorical appeals (see chapter 2):

1. *Logical or scientific warrants.* These warrants reinforce the trustworthiness of the logical progression of scientific reasoning. If a meteorologist predicts a smog alert on the basis of 90-degree temperatures, little or no winds, and heavy traffic, her warrant would be that such a formula for smog prediction is reliable.
2. *Ethical or forensic-based warrants.* A warrant is ethical when it related to values or codes of conduct such as honour, integrity, altruism, honesty, and compassion. If one argues that underrepresented minorities should be allowed the opportunity to attend college even if their admissions test scores are quite as high as the majority of admissions candidates and uses as evidence the success rate of those given such opportunity, the warrant is that society is ethically obligated to compensate minorities for past injustices by giving them such opportunities.
3. *Emotional or artistic-based warrants.* If someone argues that profanity in films weakens instead of strengthens his enjoyment of those films and uses personal testimony as evidence, the arguer's warrant is that such negative reactions to profanity in movies is a reliable criterion for evaluating the strength or weakness of a film.

Backing may also be logical, ethical, and emotional.

When analyzing the arguments of others (and even your own arguments), keep in mind that, as stated earlier, warrants – and, consequently, backing – often remain unstated. They may be certain fundamental principles or beliefs that the writer simply assumes his or her reader shares. In fact, such principles or beliefs may well be open to challenge, thus undermining the claim of the argument. But to make such a challenge, you first have to identify the unstated warrant. In making arguments of your own, consider the possibility that a good number of your readers may not share your warrant. If that is the case, it is best to state the warrant and backing directly and perhaps even offer some defense of one or both.

The Qualifier

Claims are rarely absolute; that is, a claim may be valid in many circumstances, but not necessarily in all. If that is the case, an arguer would want to **qualify** the claim so that their readers would understand how they are limiting its range. For example, someone who claims that dress codes should be eliminated in the workplace might qualify that claim by excluding workplaces where uniforms are required for reasons of security (as in the cases of police or military uniforms) or where certain articles of clothing are prohibited for reasons of personal safety (for example, wearing a necktie around heavy machinery). Someone writing about the negative influence of television on learning might qualify the claim by noting that certain forms of educational shows would be an exception.

A radical form of qualification is known as **therebuttal**. In the Toulmin scheme, rebuttal aims to show that the claim may not be as valid in certain situations. Let's use the example of dress codes mentioned above. Instead of merely qualifying the claim that dress codes should be eliminated *except for* safety reasons, the arguer might rebut the claim

entirely by agreeing with the opposition that dress codes should be maintained without exception whenever there is consensus among employers and employees alike that it is necessary and desirable.

The Rogerian Model of Argument

From Carl Rogers's (1902–1987) view, classical models of argument tend to divide people into two camps: proponents and opponents, “good guys” versus “bad guys.” For Rogers, this combative approach to argument does more harm than good; it generates ill will and antagonism between discussants rather than cooperation. The Rogerian model is an option to consider when you are addressing an audience that has deep-seated opinions on the issue and may be hostile to other perspectives.

Reflection

In the following passage from *The Moral Landscape: How Science Can Determine Human Values*, notice how neuroscientist and cultural critic Sam Harris strives to establish common ground between those who share his view that science, ideally, transcends gender or racial bias and those who claim that science cannot do so:

There is no question that scientists have occasionally demonstrated sexist and racist biases. The composition of some branches of science is still disproportionately white and male (though some are now disproportionately female), and one can reasonably wonder whether bias is the cause ... One can also argue that the contributions of women and minority groups to science have occasionally be ignored or undervalued: the case of Rosalind Franklin standing in the shadows of Crick and Watson might be an example of this. But none of these facts, alone, or in combination, or however multiplied, remotely suggests that our notions of scientific objectivity are vitiated by racism or sexism.

Consider Harris's excerpt above and reflect on how the author tries to reduce hostility between both sides of the debate on gender and racial biases in science fields.

Is his technique effective? Why or why not?

Finding Common Ground

But, you ask, how can people cooperate or interact harmoniously if they hold opposed views about an issue? Rogers's

answer is that you *find common ground and start from there*. Rogers emphasizes understanding one's *audience* (see chapter 1). A paper in the Rogerian mode assumes that readers firmly hold differing views and therefore will resist hearing others' positions. Yet no matter how debatable or controversial a view is, one can locate views on the issue on which both sides can agree. It might take a while to find them, but they are there. Consider the controversy for and against capital punishment (the death penalty):

- Both sides consider human life to be sacred and precious
- Both sides feel that capital crimes must be deterred as effectively as possible
- Both sides agree that someone convicted of a capital crime is a threat to society
- Both sides agree that it is possible for a person to be convicted of crimes that they did not commit

The virtue of finding common ground is that one can isolate and resolve the points of opposition more effectively after identifying the points of agreement because one can reduce hostility in the audience by demonstrating a true understanding of the audience's perspective.

It should be pointed out that finding common ground with those who disagree with you may take a good deal of preparation. A common criticism of the Rogerian method is that it is "wishy-washy" – that is, it creates the impression of making too many concessions of one's principles, of giving in, of not being assertive enough, and thereby losing respect. But this criticism is based on an inadequate understanding of those challenging views rather than on being conciliatory. Martin Luther King was intimately aware of his challengers' stances on the issues. He established common ground with them by calling their attention to matters they could not possibly disagree with, such as the biblically sanctioned importance of Christian brotherhood, regardless of ethnicity. Bottom line: Do your homework! Be fully aware of the foundations of your challengers' views before invoking common ground with them.

The Rogerian model emphasizes common ground (points of agreement) *before* calling attention to points of disagreement. **The writer's goal is not to win or to prove wrong; it is to work together cooperatively to arrive at an agreed upon truth or solution.** From its opening sentence, a Rogerian argument communicates a desire for harmonious interaction rather than combative opposition.

Considering Multiple Perspectives

Rogerian persuasion requires that arguers work hard at considering multiple perspectives toward issues. You must be tolerant and respectful enough of differing viewpoints to take the time to fathom the value systems that underlie them. The first step toward achieving this goal, according to Rogers, is deceptively simple: *to listen with understanding*.

Here are some suggestions for listening with understanding:

- Be as attentive as possible. Assume that the other side's positions have value.
- Suspend your own judgments while listening, keeping an open mind so you do not run the risk of judging the speaker's views before you have the chance to consider them carefully. This may mean not responding right away!
- If anything is unclear to you or you find yourself disagreeing with anything, ask questions – but only after the person has finished speaking.
- Try to see the speaker's claims in terms of his or her warrants (underlying values or ideology on which the claims are based). One better understands and appreciates a speaker's position if one is aware of these warrants.
- Think of ways in which the speaker's point of view and your own can somehow work together, despite seeming contradictory. Even if you oppose capital punishment, both of you could approach a common ground by thinking of extreme situations on either side that would discourage an inflexible stance.

Using Rogerian argument in conversation is one thing; using it in writing is another. When writing, you do not have your audience in front of you to give you immediate feedback. Instead, you have to anticipate questions and counter-

responses that challengers would have for you (in other words, automatically consider the needs of your potential audience). By considering the audience's needs and values and the merits of their beliefs, you will be more inclined to take a cooperative stance rather than a defensive or combative one.

Because the hallmark of Rogerian argument is working cooperatively with those who would otherwise be characterized as "opponents," the traditional pro-versus-con combative stance, more characteristic of Classical argument, is replaced by a problem-to-solution approach. Instead of asserting, in effect, "Here's why I'm right and you're wrong," the Rogerian arguer asserts, "Let's work together in an effort to reach consensus on identifying the problem and determining a mutually satisfactory solution."

The Rogerian Model

1. Introduction: what is our shared problem? Let's see if we can work together to resolve it.
2. Things upon which both sides agree.
3. Things upon which the two sides differ: misunderstandings, such as drawbacks or limited application to others' solutions, and the possible reasons behind these drawbacks or limitations.
4. Possible drawbacks or limitations to the *arguer's* solutions, followed by greater benefits of the arguer's solutions.
5. Options for resolving our differences; or an exhortation to accept a particular option for resolving our differences together.

When constructing an outline for a Rogerian argument, think in terms of thesis, support of thesis, and concluding judgments based on that support – just as you would with the Toulmin model. The only difference is that with the Rogerian model, you are more concerned with establishing common ground with audiences who otherwise would reject the thesis.

Writing Strong Body Paragraphs

If you haven't yet read the section of this chapter on the Toulmin model, go back and read it before you go any further in this section. Why? Because the key components of the Toulmin model – Claim, Data, Warrant, Backing, Qualifier, and Rebuttal – can be adapted to help you understand how to write strong body paragraphs. Understanding how those elements work in the Toulmin Model of essay writing will help you to translate them into academic paragraph writing.

Body paragraphs may seem complicated, but at the core, academic readerships are really looking for a few consistent elements to be in your paragraphs. Once you figure that out, the rest becomes much easier to manage. Let's start with what a paragraph is:

A paragraph is a unit of writing, made up of sentences, that focuses on developing one idea or concept.

A paragraph is a tool to organize ideas, and are typically anywhere from 5-10 sentences in

an academic essay.

There are many different types of academic paragraphs: narrative, expository, descriptive, etc. To help free yourself from the struggle of determining what your paragraph must *contain*, it can be useful instead to consider what a paragraph should *accomplish*. Ask yourself: what is the purpose of this paragraph? How does it add to the flow and development of the thesis? The number of sentences or length of a paragraph is not as important making sure that the paragraph achieves its goal: to develop one idea or concept and organize that information.

Earlier in this chapter, we discussed the 5-Paragraph Essay (an essay model taught in many North American high schools), and we noted that the “formula” for these paragraphs were typically structured in some semblance of the following:

Five Paragraph Outline

Paragraph 1	Introduction • Thesis Statement • Briefly summarize your three topic sentences
Paragraph 2	Topic Sentence Elaborate on your topic sentence Provide an example/evidence/quotation Explain the significance of the example/evidence/quotation
Paragraph 3	Topic Sentence Elaborate on your topic sentence Provide an example/evidence/quotation Explain the significance of the example/evidence/quotation
Paragraph 4	Topic Sentence Elaborate on your topic sentence Provide an example/evidence/quotation Explain the significance of the example/evidence/quotation
Paragraph 5	Conclusion • Summarize your three topic sentences • Discuss how the ideas in paragraphs 2-4 support your thesis

Take a closer look at the objectives of the body paragraphs in the outline above. The expectation is to provide a topic sentence (what Toulmin would call a **claim**); some context for the topic sentence; an example, evidence or quotation (or **data**); and the significance of the evidence provided (**backing**). The major component missing in this outline is the **warrant**, the incorporation of which helps to elevate your writing in a post-secondary context and gives it more finesse. In a body paragraph at this level, the **warrant** would explain the evidence to the reader and how they should interpret it. You might also include **rebuttals** or **qualifiers** in your body paragraphs, as needed, to help demonstrate that you have considered the other side of the debate or topic. Essentially, what you may have learned in high school about writing paragraphs is helpful, but we need to remember that paragraph writing is not formulaic or prescriptive: paragraphs should focus on **one idea/concept** develop that idea or concept fully.

Take note that you do not have to have all components in every paragraph, nor are there a prescribed number or particular order in which you must present these elements. Finding your own natural **flow** (or the structure of how you present ideas and information) is something that you will develop in the course of your essay and will evolve over time as you practice academic writing.

While your professors may not know it consciously, many of them have been trained to write academic body paragraphs in this way. Through trial, error, and critique from *their* professors, your instructors have intuitively come to know what must be present in a body paragraph in order for it to be effective.

Self-Practice

Take a look at the following excerpt from an [academic journal article](#). See if you can identify the different elements of the Toulmin model (listed below) in the paragraphs:

- Claim (topic sentence)
- Data (evidence)
- Warrant (explanation of the evidence)
- Backing (connection of claim, data, and warrant to the thesis statement)
- Qualifier (exceptions to the claim or misconceptions)
- Rebuttal (explanation of why the other side is incorrect)

Casey, B. J., & Caudle, K. (2013). The teenage brain: Self control. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 22(2), 82-87. doi:10.1177/0963721413480170

Adolescence, by definition, involves new demands on the individual as she or he moves from dependence on the family unit to relative independence. This developmental period is not specific to humans, as evidenced by the increases in novelty seeking, interactions with peers, and fighting with parents observed in other species (see Romeo, 2013; Spear, 2013; both in this issue). These behaviors are thought to have evolved to serve adaptive functions related to successful mating and obtainment of resources necessary for survival (Spear & Varlinskaya, 2010). A heightened sensitivity to socially relevant cues (e.g., peers, monetary gain) would seem to be an ideal mechanism for meeting some of these developmental challenges. However, such a system may appear less than optimal when the pull by these socially relevant cues comes at the expense of long-term goals and the overall well-being of the adolescent.

To suggest that this period of development is one of no brakes or steering wheel (Bell & McBride, 2010) is to greatly oversimplify it. In a series of recent experiments in our laboratory (Somerville, Hare, & Casey, 2011), we measured self control using a variant of a go/no-go paradigm that contained social cues (positive, negative, or neutral facial expressions). By using socially relevant and emotionally salient stimuli together with neutral stimuli, we could test how well adolescents regulated their impulses in both emotional and non-emotional contexts (Hare et al., 2008; Somerville et al., 2011). Self-control—in this case, suppressing a compelling action—showed a different developmental pattern in the context of emotional information than in its absence, especially for males (Tottenham, Hare, & Casey, 2011). As illustrated in Figure 1 (also see Fig. 1 in Hare et al., 2008; National Research Council, 2011), when no emotional information is present, not only do many adolescents perform as well as adults, some perform even better. However, when decisions are required in the heat of the moment (i.e., in the presence of emotional cues; Fig. 2a), performance falters (Fig. 2b). Specifically, adolescents have difficulty suppressing a response to appetitive social cues relative to neutral ones. This diminished ability is not observed in children and adults, who show equal difficulty in suppressing responses regardless of the emotional content of the non-target. Thus, the description of teens as “all gasoline, no brakes, and no steering wheel” more accurately reflects their behavior in heated situations than in cool, less immediate, and less emotional ones. In these cool situations, the teen appears to be capable of acting rationally and making optimal decisions.

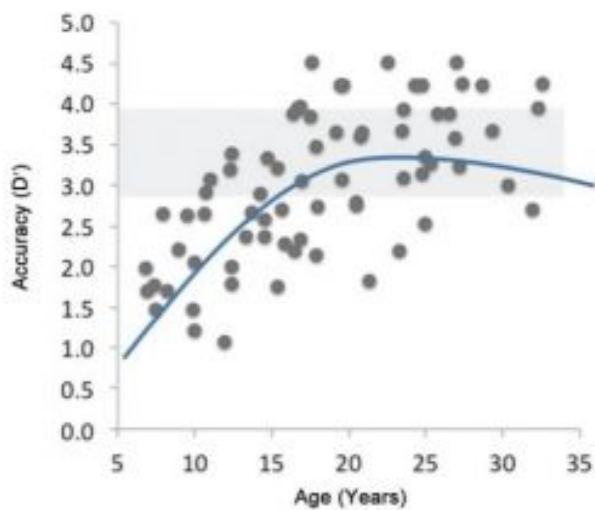
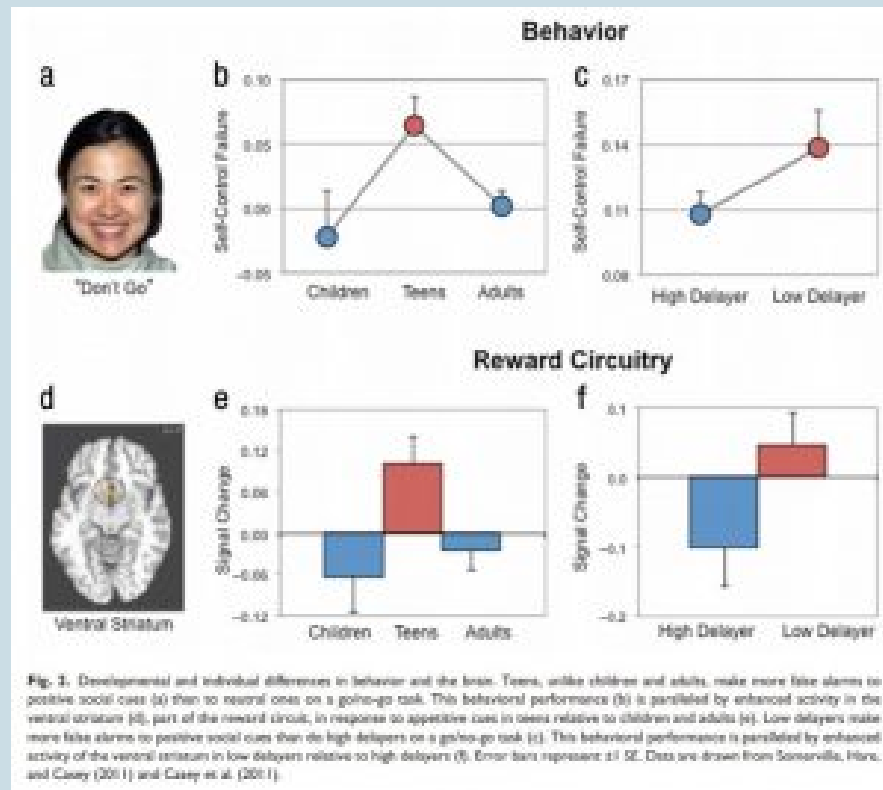


Fig. 1. Performance on a standard go/no-go task as a function of age. D' was used as a measure of accuracy that includes both hits and false alarms. The data illustrate improvements in performance with age but also high variability, with some adolescents performing as well as or better than some adults (highlighted by the gray box). Data are drawn from Hare et al. (2008) and National Research Council (2011).



Writing Academic Introductions and Conclusions

It may seem a bit strange to come to introductions and conclusions as the last part of this chapter, but it's actually rather fitting: for many people, the introduction and conclusion are the final parts of an essay that they write.

So, first thing's first: what should you include in an **academic introduction**?

- **A useful opening statement.** Do not start with clichéd openings like: "Since the dawn of time..." or "For as long as man has walked the Earth..." Why should you avoid these? They typically don't add anything to your essay. The introduction should start off strong with an opening that (ideally) addresses the *who*, *what*, *when*, and *where* of your topic. For example: "The Rwandan civil war took place from 1 October 1990 to 18 July 1994 in the Republic of Rwanda, one of the smallest countries in Africa." An exception here would be if you are writing a less-academic essay, such as a narrative essay. In such a case you may wish to use an anecdotal or startling opening to catch your reader's interest.
- **Provide both geographic and temporal context.** Make sure to be specific about the location upon which your essay focuses and the time period. Are you looking at current Ebola vaccines in the United Kingdom? The history of Russian monarchies? You cannot assume that your reader will know the *when* and *where* of your essay

intuitively.

- **Major points** that you will be making to support the thesis. These should be the main reasons that you are offering to your audience to support your position. Some students worry about “disclosing too much” in the introduction and losing reader interest. Academic readers don’t like surprises – they like to know the arguments up front so that they can follow them as they read your essay. If your thesis and arguments are interesting, your reader will be interested and you won’t need gimmicks or tricks to keep them focused.
- **The thesis statement.** Depending on the type and purpose of your essay, your thesis statement will change to reflect those goals. Whether you use an informative thesis, argumentative thesis, etc., your thesis should still have two fundamental components:
 1. The claim or assertion – the point you are trying to make
 2. The significance – the analytical component that establishes why your claim is important and makes sense. This portion of the thesis usually involves the word “because” (or a synonym for “because”) in order to demonstrate the relationship between the claim and the significance.

Academic conclusions involve more than simply restating what has already been said throughout the paper (though yes, a conclusion should summarize the essay concisely). *You should not be introducing any new ideas in your conclusion.* The conclusion is a good place to bring all of the threads and ideas from your paper together (synthesis) to answer your research question, reiterate your thesis statement, and highlight to your reader the connections and significances that they should take away from your paper.

A conclusion can also do a few other things, depending upon the nature of your essay. Some strategies you may wish to try can include:

- Make note of any further research or explorations that could be done on the topic
- Propose a course of action or possible solution to a problem
- Identify broader implications related to your conclusions
- Share insights or revelations that emerged from the essay
- Explain the significance of your research within larger academic contexts and discussions

Remember: the conclusion is not the place to stick in random ideas, information, or thoughts that you couldn’t fit into your paper elsewhere. Like your body paragraphs, the conclusion should be focused and bring the reader to a natural stopping place.

Chapter 6: Key Terms and Concepts

- Five-Paragraph Essay
- Flow
- Expository essays
- Argumentative essays
- Reflective & Critique essays
- Feldman’s Method of Art Criticism
- Narrative essays
- Compare & Contrast essays
- Toulmin model

- Claim
- Data
- Warrant
- Backing
- Qualifier
- Rebuttal
- Rogerian model
- Body paragraphs
- Introductions
- Conclusions

7. Additional Resources

APA and MLA Referencing:

Purdue University's Online Writing Lab: https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/purdue_owl.html
A credible authority on all things citation and referencing

Academic Writing and Research Strategies:

Graff, G. & Birkenstein, C. (n.d.) *They say, I say: Moves that matter in academic writing*, 4th ed. Norton: New York. Retrieved from: <https://gcccd.instructure.com/courses/19948/files/1386585/download?verifier=qIDOpQgDo7iQtgNniJipootfG5ZXT5jvOwiQoxkc&wrap=1>
An excellent undergraduate primer on how to “write academically” – this small-but-mighty book is a reference staple of university undergrads

Sheridan College Library Services: <http://sheridancollege.libguides.com/research>
Research guides, citation help, research and academic skills

Excelsior Online Writing Lab: <https://owl.excelsior.edu/>
An excellent resource for students that covers all types of subjects related to academic writing. There is a particularly robust section for English Language Learners (ELL)

Harvard Writes: <http://harvardwrites.com/>
Run by Harvard University in the States, this website focuses on what sets academic research apart and how to excel at the process.

Grammarly Blog Handbook: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/category/handbook/>
If English grammar and writing are a struggle for you, this is a one-stop website for all things related to writing mechanics.

Scribbr: <https://www.scribbr.com/>
A website that contains a lot of tools and information about the writing and research process at the post-secondary level.